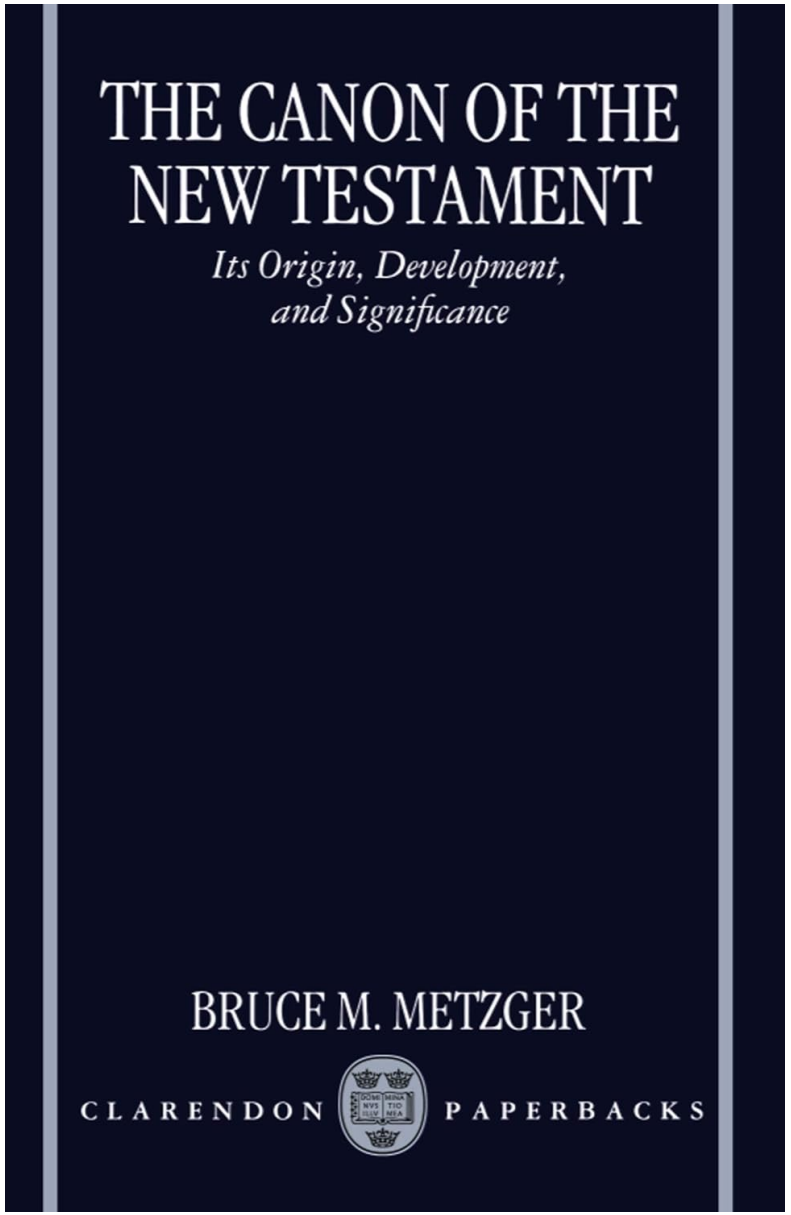
Class 1:
Introduction to the Canon of the NT

Based on B. Metzger, *The Canon of the New Testament: Its Origin, Development, and Significance,* Oxford (1987)

Sources

- Primarily: Bruce Metzger, *The Canon of the New Testament: Its Origin, Development, and Significance* (Oxford: 1987)
- This book is considered the standard work on the NT canon
- Other sources used as well (such as my work on 1 and 2 Peter)
  - Unless otherwise stated, assume all material is from Metzger



Download Slides

- https://joshuahaub.com/notes/nt-canon/



What is “the Canon”?

- “Much of the present confusion over the problem of canon turns on the failure to reach an agreement regarding terminology” (Brevard Childs as quoted by M. Kruger, *Canon Revisited*, p. 27)
- Metzger: “Still more basic are the questions of whether the canon is a collection of authoritative books or an authoritative collection of books—and in either case whether the collection can be held to reflect the divine intention within the history of salvation” (Metzger, p. 1)
- Definition for this study: **the canon is “a closed list of authoritative, sacred texts”** (undergraduate professor, 2026)

What is “the Canon”?

the canon is “a closed list of authoritative, sacred texts”
(undergraduate professor, 2026)

#1: “Canon”

- The term “canon” comes from the Greek word meaning, “rule” or “standard” (3x in 2 Cor 10:13-16; 1x in Gal 6:16)
- It is believed by some that Athanasius (4th century) was the first person to use the term in reference to a “canon of sacred Scripture” (matches our OT and NT)

Athanasius (367 AD)

… 1. They have fabricated books which they call books of tables[5], in which they shew stars, to which they give the names of Saints. And therein of a truth they have inflicted on themselves a double reproach: those who have written such books, because they have perfected themselves in a lying and contemptible science; and as to the ignorant and simple, they have led them astray by evil thoughts concerning the right faith established in all truth and upright in the presence of God.

… 2. But since we have made mention of heretics as dead, but of ourselves as possessing the Divine Scriptures for salvation; and since I fear lest, as Paul wrote to the Corinthians[7], some few of the simple should be beguiled from their simplicity and purity, by the subtilty of certain men, and should henceforth read other books—those called apocryphal—led astray by the

… 2. But since we have made mention of heretics as dead, but of ourselves as possessing the Divine Scriptures for salvation; and since I fear lest, as Paul wrote to the Corinthians[7], some few of the simple should be beguiled from their simplicity and purity, by the subtilty of certain men, and should henceforth read other books—those called apocryphal—led astray by the similarity of their names with the true books; I beseech you to bear patiently, if I also write, by way of remembrance, of matters with which you are acquainted, influenced by the need and advantage of the Church.

3. In proceeding to make mention of these things, I shall adopt, to commend my undertaking, the pattern of Luke the Evangelist, saying on my own account: 'Forasmuch as some have taken in hand,' to reduce into order for themselves the books termed apocryphal, and to mix them up with the divinely inspired Scripture, concerning which we have been fully persuaded, as they who from the beginning were eye-witnesses and ministers of the Word, delivered to the fathers; it seemed p 552 good to me also, having been urged thereto by true brethren, and having learned from the beginning, to set before you the books

included in the Canon, and handed down, and accredited as Divine; to the end that any one who has fallen into error may condemn those who have led him astray; and that he who has continued stedfast in purity may again rejoice, having these things brought to his remembrance.

4. There are, then, **of the Old Testament, twenty-two books in number**; for, as I have heard, it is handed down that this is the number of the letters among the Hebrews; their respective order and names being as follows. The first is Genesis, then Exodus, next Leviticus, after that Numbers, and then Deuteronomy. Following these there is Joshua, the son of Nun, then Judges, then Ruth. And again, after these four books of Kings, the first and second being reckoned as one book, and so likewise the third and fourth as one book. And again, the first and second of the Chronicles are reckoned as one book. Again Ezra, the first and second are similarly one book. After these there is the book of Psalms, then the Proverbs, next Ecclesiastes, and the Song of Songs. Job follows, then the Prophets, the twelve being reckoned as one book. Then Isaiah, one book, then Jeremiah with Baruch, Lamentations, and[2] the epistle,

Job follows, then the Prophets, the twelve being reckoned as one book. Then Isaiah, one book, then Jeremiah with Baruch, Lamentations, and[2] the epistle, one book; afterwards, Ezekiel and Daniel, each one book. Thus far constitutes the Old Testament.

5. Again it is not tedious to speak of the [books] of the New Testament. These are, the four Gospels, according to **Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John**. Afterwards, the **Acts of the Apostles** and Epistles (called Catholic), seven, viz. **of James, one; of Peter, two; of John, three; after these, one of Jude**. In addition, there are **fourteen Epistles of Paul**, written in this order. The first, to the Romans; then two to the Corinthians; after these, to the Galatians; next, to the Ephesians; then to the Philippians; then to the Colossians; after these, two to the Thessalonians, and that to the Hebrews; and again, two to Timothy; one to Titus; and lastly, that to Philemon. And besides, **the Revelation of John**.

6. These are fountains of salvation, that they who thirst may be satisfied with the living words they contain. In these alone is proclaimed the doctrine of godliness. Let no man add to these, neither let him take ought from these. For

godliness. Let no man add to these, neither let him take ought from these. For concerning these the Lord put to shame the Sadducees, and said, ‘Ye do err, not knowing the Scriptures.’ And He reproved the Jews, saying, ‘Search the Scriptures, for these are they that testify of Me.’

7. But for greater exactness I add this also, writing of necessity; that there are other books besides these not indeed included in the Canon, but appointed by the Fathers to be read by those who newly join us, and who wish for instruction in the word of godliness. The Wisdom of Solomon, and the Wisdom of Sirach, and Esther, and Judith, and Tobit, and that which is called the Teaching of the Apostles, and the Shepherd. But the former, my brethren, are included in the Canon, the latter being [merely] read; nor is there in any place a mention of apocryphal writings. But they are an invention of heretics, who write them when they choose, bestowing upon them their approbation, and assigning to them a date, that so, using them as ancient writings, they may find occasion to lead astray the simple.

apocryphal writings. But they are an invention of heretics, who write them when they choose, bestowing upon them their approbation, and assigning to them a date, that so, using them as ancient writings, they may find occasion to lead astray the simple.

Athanasius of Alexandria, "Festal Letters," in St. Athanasius: Select Works and Letters, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace, trans. Henry Burgess and Jessie Smith Payne, vol. 4 of A Select Library of the Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers of the Christian Church, Second Series (New York: Christian Literature Company, 1892), 551–552.

For free: https://www.bible-researcher.com/athanasius.html

What is “the Canon”?

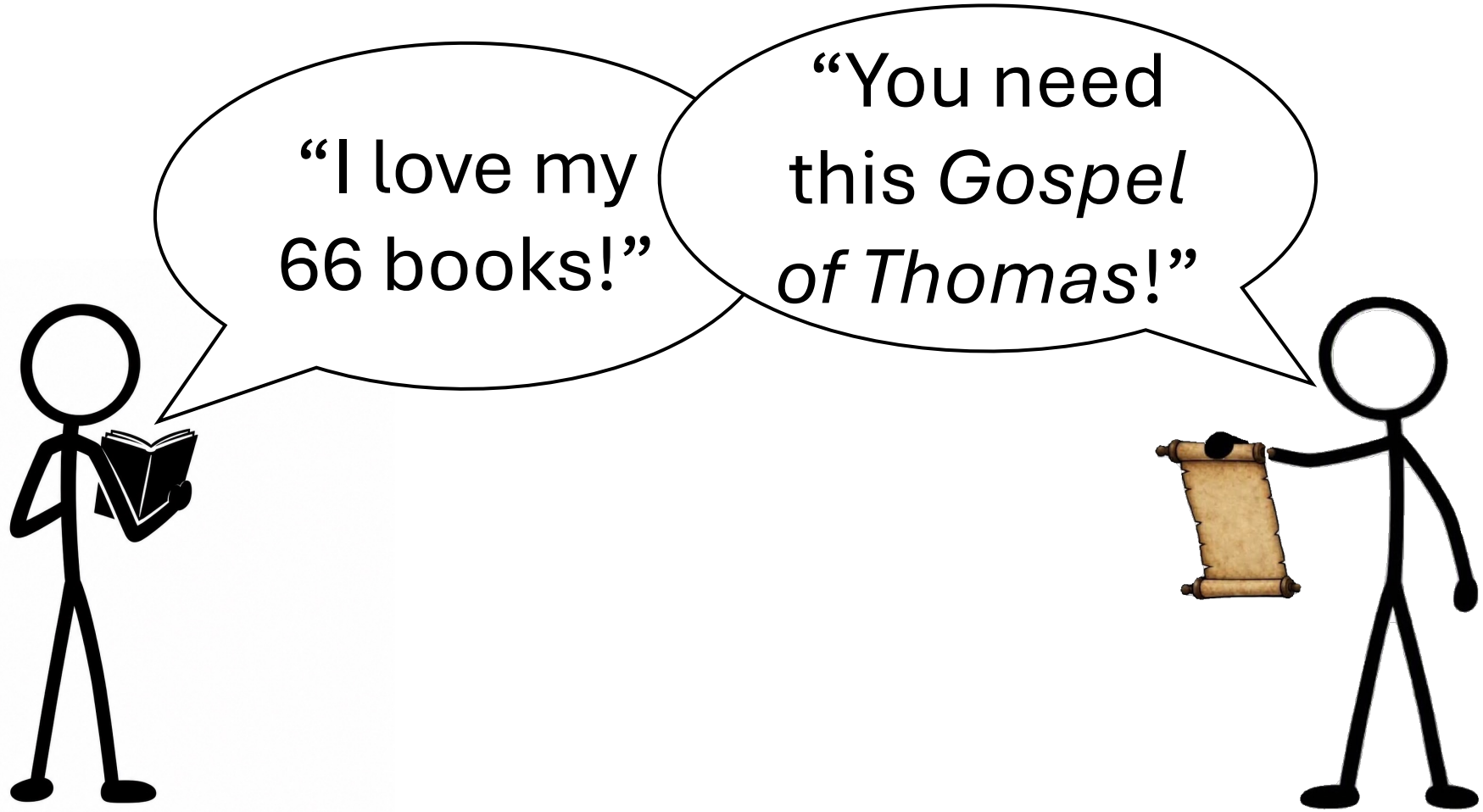
the canon is “a closed list of authoritative, sacred texts”
(undergraduate professor, 2026)

#2: “Closed”

- “Closed” means: There are no new books being added

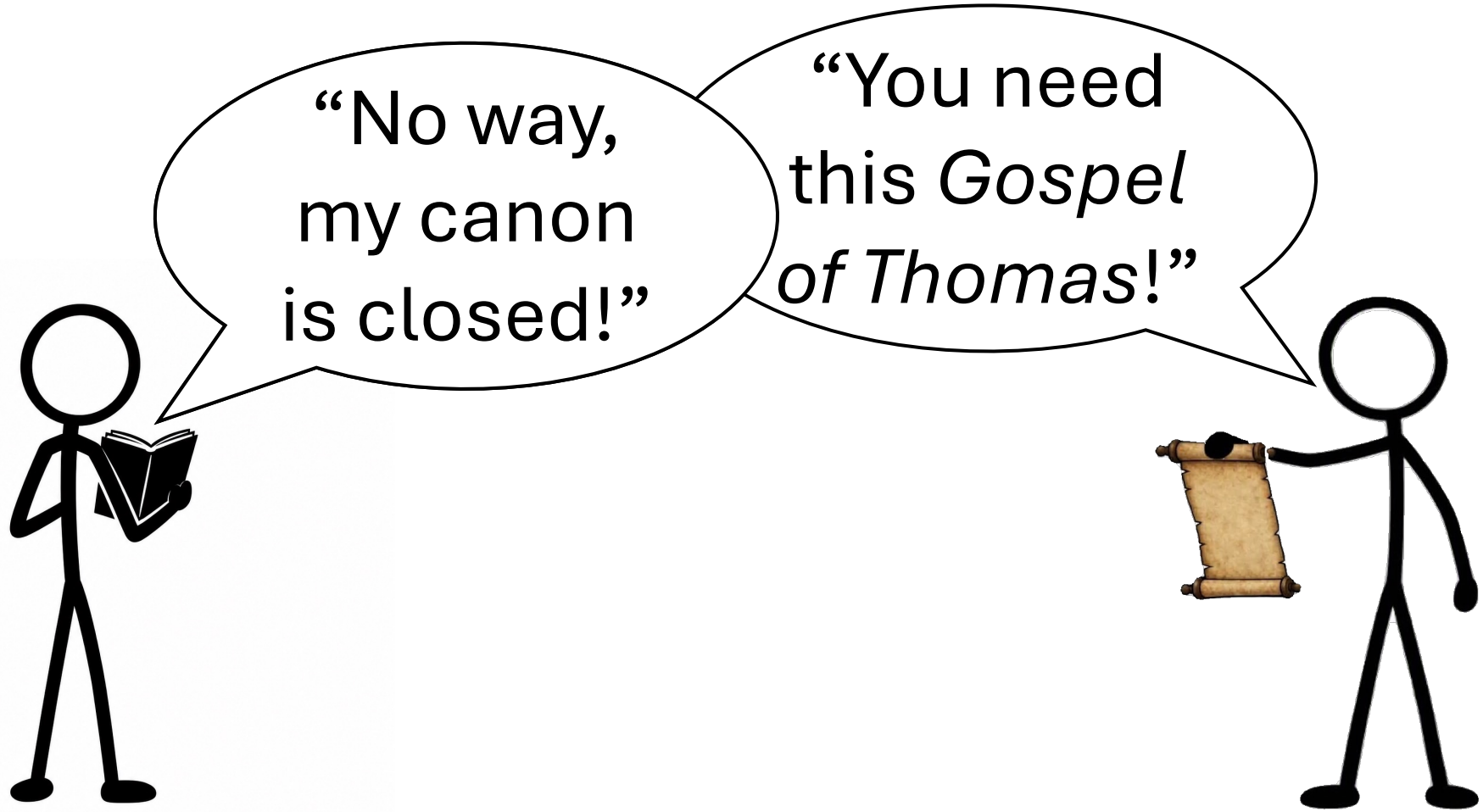
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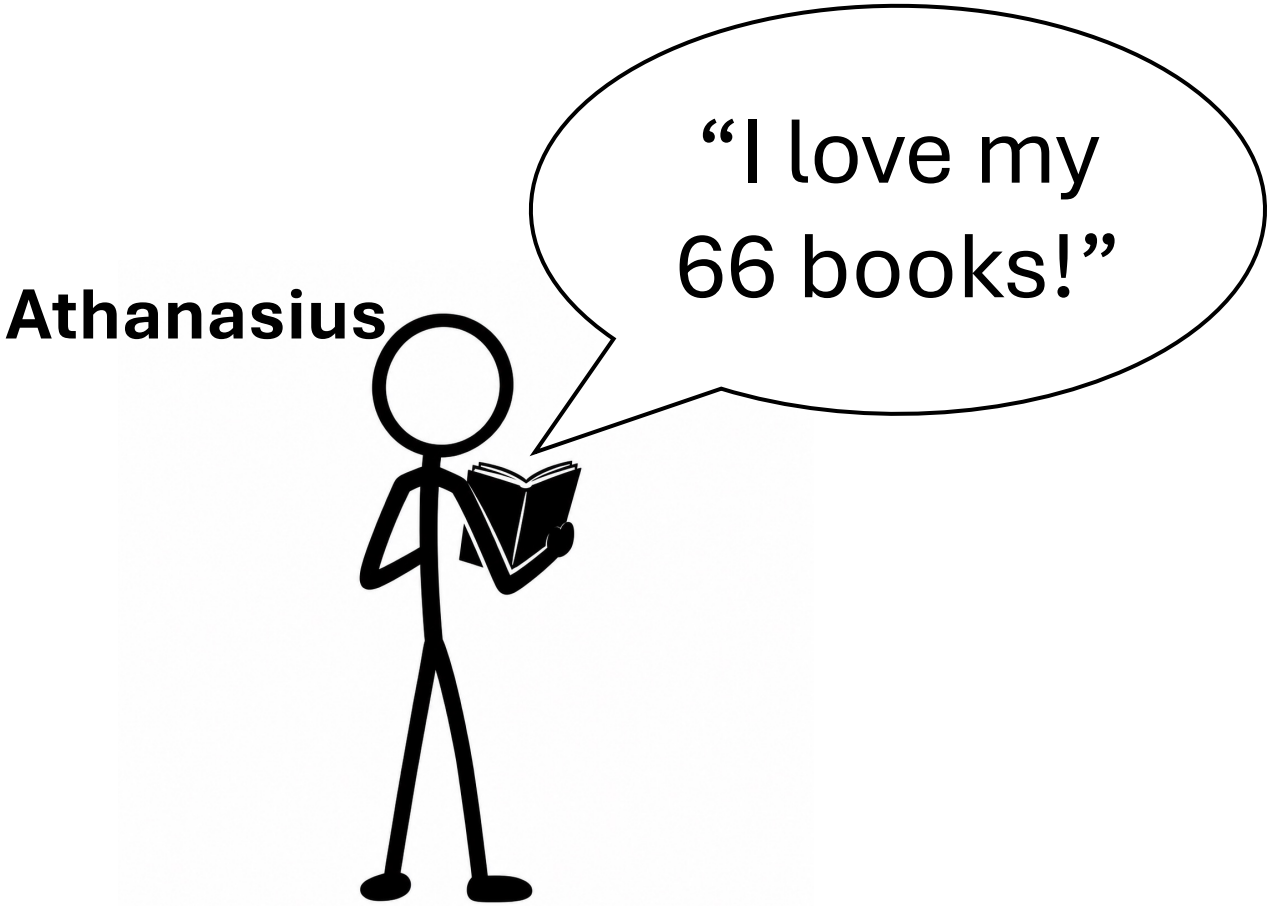
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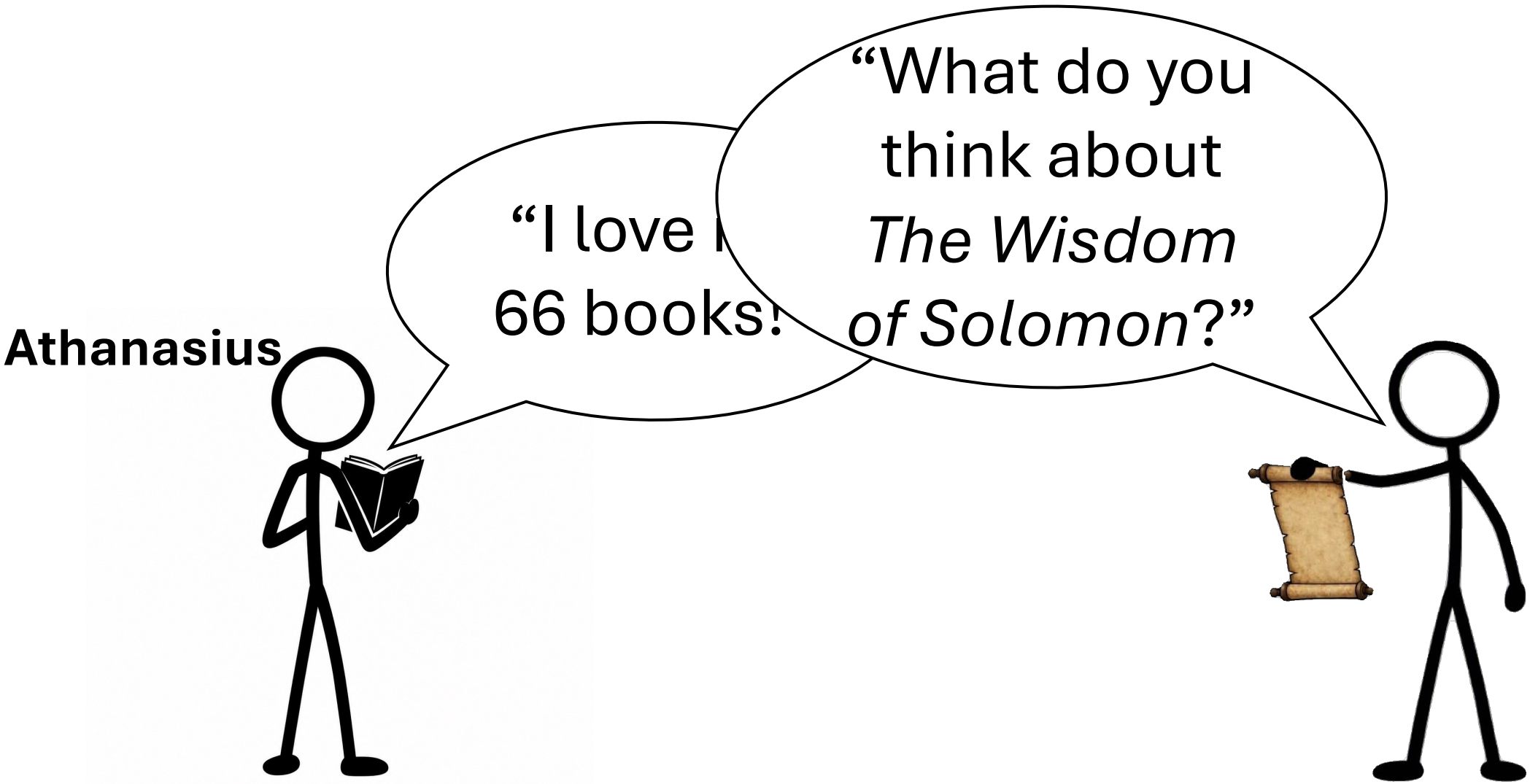
#3: “Authoritative, Sacred”

- “Authoritative” means something like: “Ought to be listened to”
- “Sacred” means: “holy,” “important,” etc.

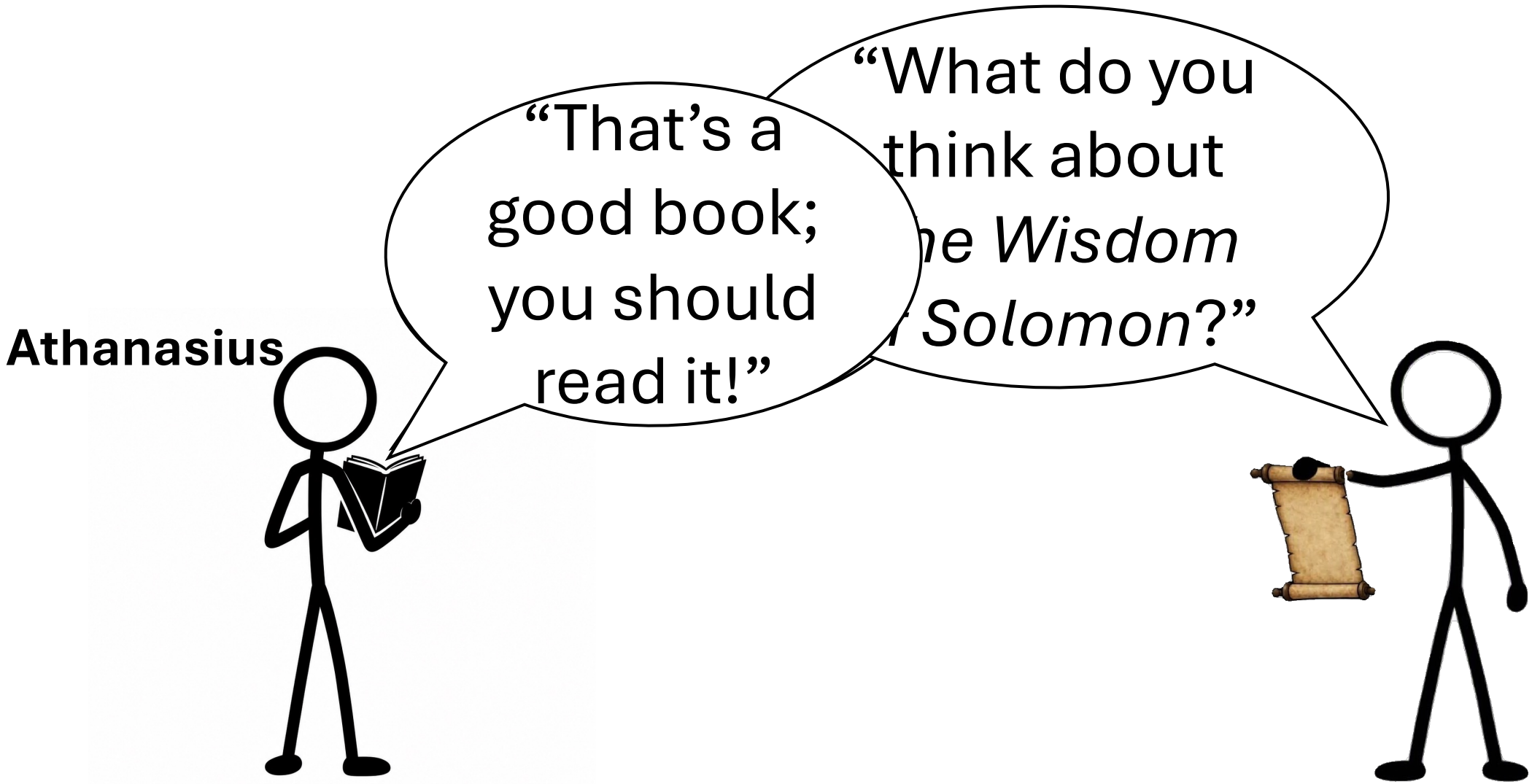
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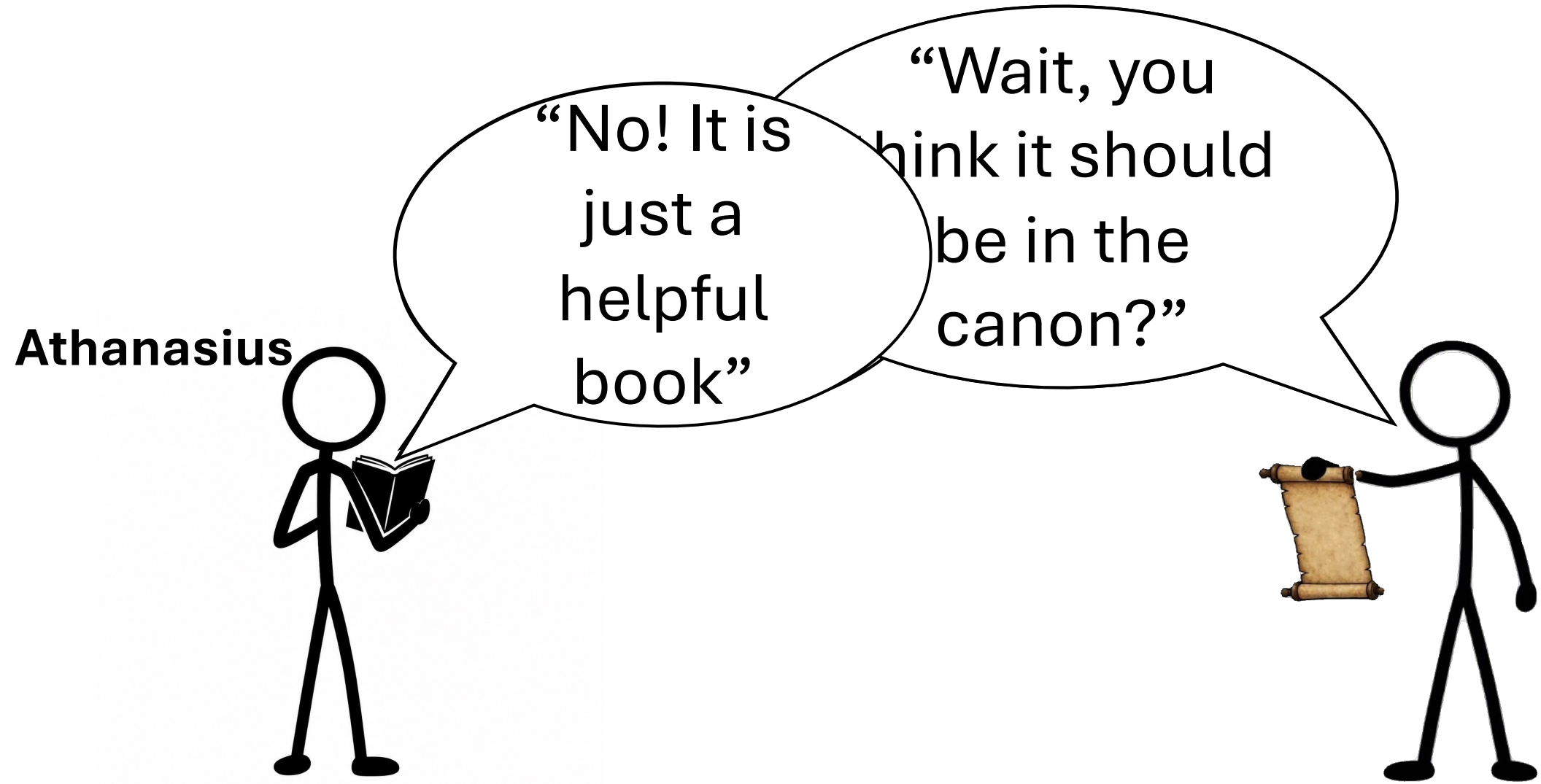


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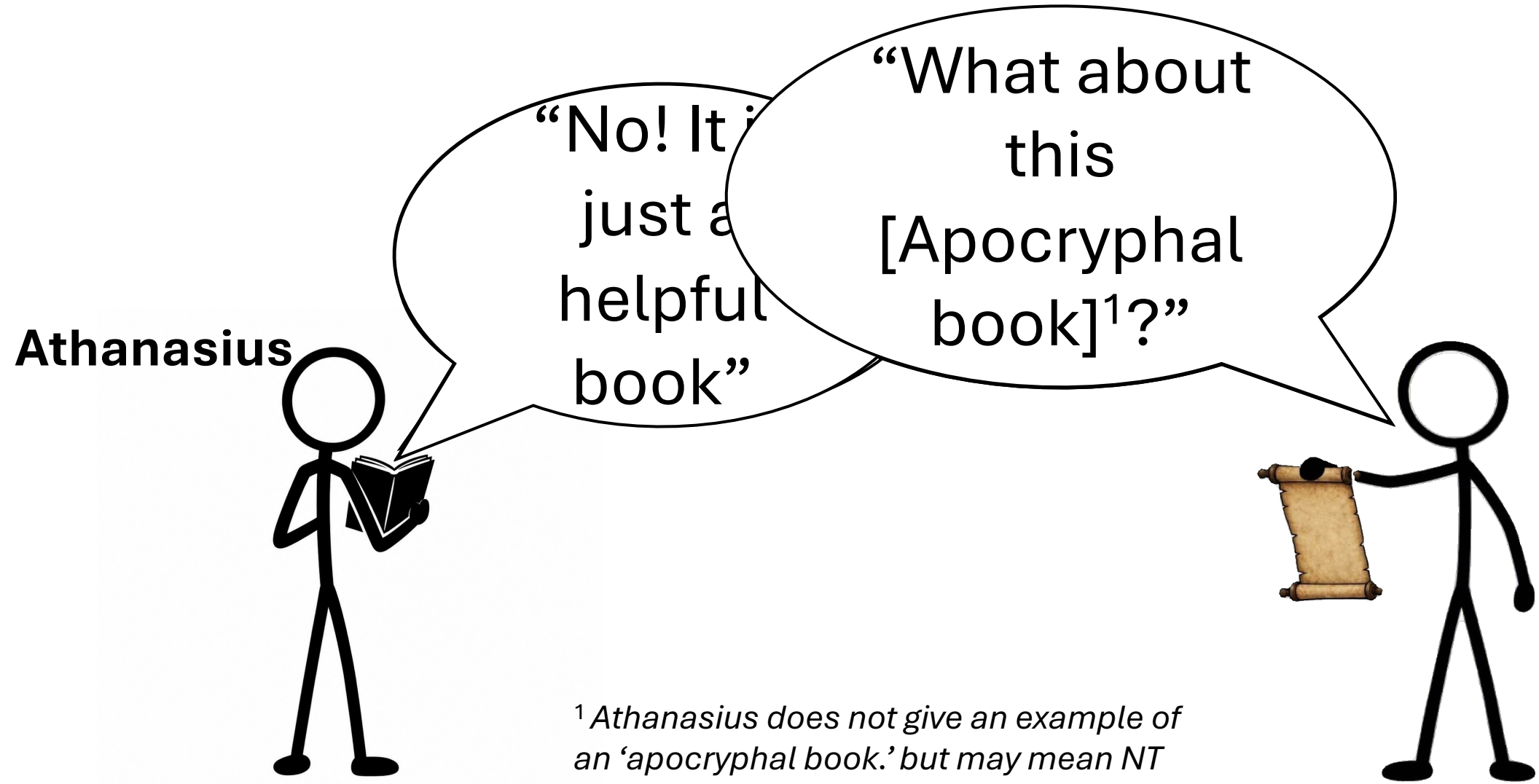


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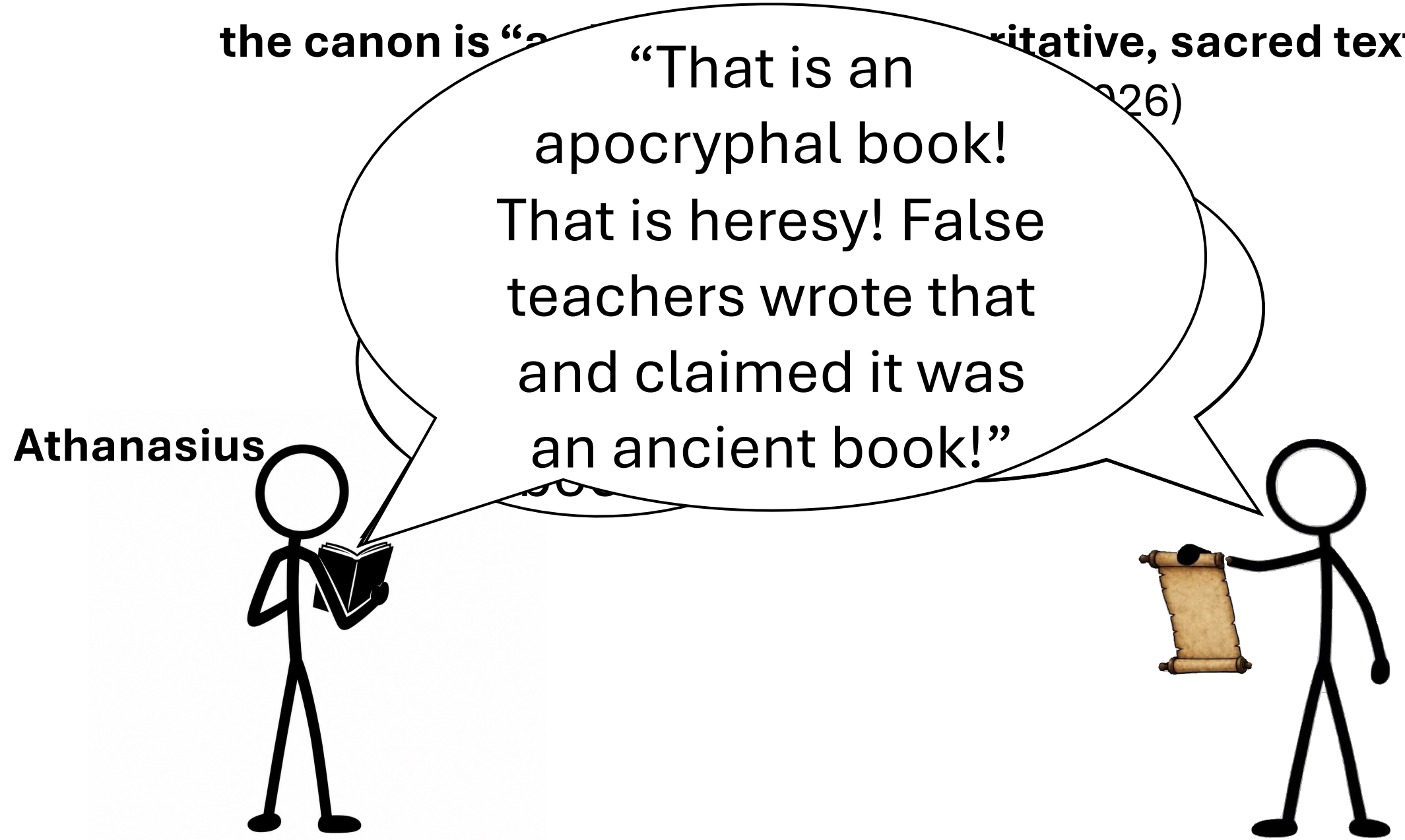


[1] *Athanasius does not give an example of an ‘apocryphal book.’ but may mean NT apocryphal like ‘Gospel of Thomas’*

the canon is “a … ritative, sacred texts”

…926)

Athanasius



Pushback to this Definition (by M. Kruger)

- Notes Sundberg's version: "the canon…[is] a final, fixed, closed list" (*Canon Revisited*, p. 35)
- Canon ≠ Scripture, the Canon is *made up of* "Scripture"
- "the strict demarcation between Scripture and canon may seem clear to Sundberg, it seems difficult to imagine these two concepts being separated within the minds of, say, second-century Christians. In order to recognize a certain book to be Scripture in the first place, an early Christian would have needed to be able to say another book in his library was *not* Scripture…. the term *Scripture* already implies exclusion and limitation to some degree, making a sharp distinction between Scripture and canon more difficult to sustain" (p. 36)

Pushback to this Definition (by M. Kruger)

- “before this time most of the New Testament books had already been functioning with sacred authority for generations, and their place in the New Testament corpus was fully secure. The supposed closing of the canon in the fourth century neither changed their status nor increased their authority—it was already as high as it could be. In regard to the function of these books, one could rightly say there was already a canon, or at least the category of a canon, well before the fourth century. Sundberg’s definition is so focused on the final stage of the canon’s development that it misses the fact that it is, after all, a *stage*—and therefore is intimately connected to, and dependent on, what has come before.... the concept of canon cannot be reduced to a single point of time. It is best conceived of as a continuum—less like a dot and more like a line” (p. 37)

Pushback to this Definition (by M. Kruger)

"from the perspective of God's revelational activity, a canon exists as soon as the New Testament books are written—the canon is always the books God has given to the corporate church, no more, no less" (p. 38)

3 Definitions of “Canon” (see p. 58)

- The “Exclusive” definition: “A final, closed list; the final reception of a set of books” (as we have been discussing)
- The “Functional” definition: “A set of books used as authoritative texts in the community”
- The “Ontological” definition: “The scriptural books that God gave the corporate church”

3 Definitions of “Canon” (see p. 58)

- The “Ontological” definition: “The scriptural books that God gave the corporate church”

“God’s books are authoritative prior to anyone using them or recognizing them. Surely, the existence of canon and the recognition of canon are two distinguishable phenomena. Why, then, should the term *canon* be restricted to only the latter? This distinction is critical because it reminds us that neither the church’s use of these books (functional definition) nor the church’s final reception of these books (exclusive definition) is what *makes* them canonical. They are canonical by virtue of what they *are*, namely, God’s books” (p. 58)

3 Definitions of “Canon” (see p. 58)

Exclusive, Functional, Ontological

“If we are to be balanced, it seems we need *three* aspects to our definition of canon: canon as reception (exclusive), canon as use (functional), and canon as divinely given (ontological). As we shall discuss further below, we are not forced to choose between these three, but can recognize that each of them captures true aspects of canon. When all three are considered in tandem, their weaknesses can be balanced out, and a more well-rounded understanding of canon can emerge” (pp. 58-59)

When is the Canon Established?

Ontological

1st century AD



Functional

2nd century AD



Exclusive

4th century AD



Pushback to Kruger

- The question is, "*Which* books did God give us?"
- It is true that the books we should have in our canon are books "from God," but the ancient church debated on *which* books those were!
- We will not be abandoning the definition of "canon," but Kruger does give a good reminder that God had a part to play in the creation of the books

Misunderstanding “Scripture” in the NT

- 2 Timothy 3:16-17 (c. 1st century): “All Scripture” = OT Scripture, not “All the Bible” (NT canon not formed yet)

- 2 Peter 3:16 (c. 50AD-100AD) = Paul’s letters being equated with OT Scripture BUT STILL not “All the Bible” (NT canon not formed yet)

Class 2:
History of Canon Discussion (19th century)

Based on B. Metzger, *The Canon of the New Testament: Its Origin, Development, and Significance,* Oxford (1987)

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History of Canon Discussion

- Middle Ages: few quotes about the NT books
- Renaissance / Reformation: occasional questions about authorship of Hebrews, several of the Catholic Epistles, and Revelation, but “no one dared seriously to dispute their canonicity” (Metzger: p. 11)
- Luther: Hebrews, James, Jude, and Revelation are “inferior” but did not omit them from their translations of the NT (p. 11)
- Questions about the Canon arouse because of the Deistic movement

History of Canon Discussion



History of Canon Discussion

367 AD

Athanasius:
OT/NT

History of Canon Discussion

Renaissance and Reformation

Luther: “inferior” books, but
still includes in his NT

History of Canon Discussion

1698

John Toland

"He disputed the royal authorship of the *Eikon Basilike*…Toland took occasion to insinuate that, as people were mistaken on [the authorship of *Eikon Basilike*], so **they might be also about the authenticity of many of the early writings of Christianity**, including presumably books of the New Testament" (p. 12)

History of Canon Discussion

Jan 30, 1699

Reverend Offspring Blackall

- Preached a sermon before the House of Commons
- A chaplain of King William's "charged Toland with creating a scandal by what he had written" (p. 12)

History of Canon Discussion

1699

John Toland

Response: claimed that his earlier statements were only about the apocryphal writings, not the NT

“In the next breath, however, Toland raised questions that must, on the face of it, cast down on the validity of accepting as canonical several books of the New Testament” (p. 12)

1699

John Toland

“Thus he admitted that several spurious pieces are quoted by the Fathers as of equal authority with those that are generally received in the New Testament” (p. 12)

“He urged also that he could not understand why the writings of Mark and Luke should be accepted as canonical whereas those attributed to Clement of Rome and Barnabas are refused, since all four authors were equally companions and fellow-labourers with the apostles. In fact, Toland went so far as to declare, in so many words, that there is not one single book of the New Testament which was not refused by some of the ancient writers as being unjustly attributed to the apostles and as actually forged by their adversaries” (p. 12-13)

History of Canon Discussion

1699

John Toland

History of Canon Discussion

1700-1719

Samuel Clarke, Stephen Nye,
John Richardson, and others

- Strongly denounced Toland
- Richardson: “What the Apostles Wrote, and what they Authoriz’d, can be known in no other way, then by the Testimonies of those who liv’d at the same time with them, and the Tradition of those who succeeded them” (p. 13)

History of Canon Discussion

1726-1727

Jeremiah Jones

Used the “New and Full Method” of looking at ancient records to find early testimony or traditions of people concerning NT books written close to them in time

History of Canon Discussion

1726-1727

Jeremiah Jones

Jones made available for the first time an English translation of the text of dozens of apocryphal writings” (p. 14)

History of Canon Discussion

1699 (in France)

Jacques Basnage

Found that during the first 3 centuries “there was no decision concerning the limits of the New Testament canon, but each local church had the liberty to choose or reject individual books; this freedom was most noticeable among Eastern Churches in rejecting the Apocalypse” (p. 16)

History of Canon Discussion

1804-1812

J. G. Eichhorn

“The first to attribute to Marcion the stimulus to collect the New Testament writings, and argued that the core of the future canon was established by about AD 175” (p. 18)

History of Canon Discussion

1826

W. M. L. De Wette

“Extended the history of the gradual development of the canon up to the year 400” (p. 18)

History of Canon Discussion

1826 (in America)

Archibald Alexander

- Wrote the first book (in the US) dealing solely with the Biblical canon
- "Argued that **<u>the criterion of New Testament canonicity is apostolic authorship</u>**, whether direct or indirect (the latter in the case of Mark and Luke). Apostolicity is to be established by historically verified testimonies of patristic writers of the early Christian centuries" (p. 18)

History of Canon Discussion

1866

Constantin von Tischendorf

Argued the canon of the NT was established by the beginning of the 2nd century

History of Canon Discussion

1855 (in Britian)

Brooke Foss Westcott

Said that the formulation of the canon was one of “the first instinctive acts of the Christian society, resting upon the general confession of the Churches and not upon independent opinions of its members” (p. 21)

History of Canon Discussion

1874-1877

Walter R. Cassels

Wrote an anonymous work in three volumes which revived some of the old arguments of 18th century Deism. His “purpose was to show from patristic testimony that the canonical Gospels are so far removed in time from the events they record that they lose all competence as witnesses to the reality of the miraculous” (p. 22)

History of Canon Discussion

1894

Adolf Jülicher

“Said that the public reading…of Christian books and epistles in a liturgical setting, along with Old Testament books already regarded as authoritative, that was chiefly responsible for their being recognized eventually as canonical Scripture” (p. 23)

History of Canon Discussion

1888-1901

Theodor Zahn

Believed the canon “came into existence by the end of the first century” (p. 23-24)

History of Canon Discussion

1889

Adolf Harnack

- Chief rival against Zahn
- Said that the canon was one of the three barriers which the Church created to defend against heresies such as Gnosticism (the other two were the creed and the bishopric)
- The process was a “competition” of books and the most helpful survived

History of Canon Discussion

1888-1901

Theodor Zahn

“Understood [the canon] as a collection of books possessing authority, but he did not insist that this authority should be based on the thesis that ‘the New Testament is holy Scripture’” (p. 24)

1889

Adolf Harnack

History of Canon Discussion

1888-1901

Theodor Zahn

"He was satisfied if, for instance, the four Gospels are an authority because of the authority of the Lord's sayings which they contain. He could…speak of the existence of a NT 'canon' [at the close of the 1st century]" (p. 24)

1889

Adolf Harnack

"New Testament canon is a collection of books that possessed authority *because* they were regarded as holy Scripture. Accordingly he placed the rise of the New Testament canon at the close of the 2nd century" (p. 24)

Class 3:
History of Canon Discussion (20th century)

Based on B. Metzger, *The Canon of the New Testament: Its Origin, Development, and Significance,* Oxford (1987)

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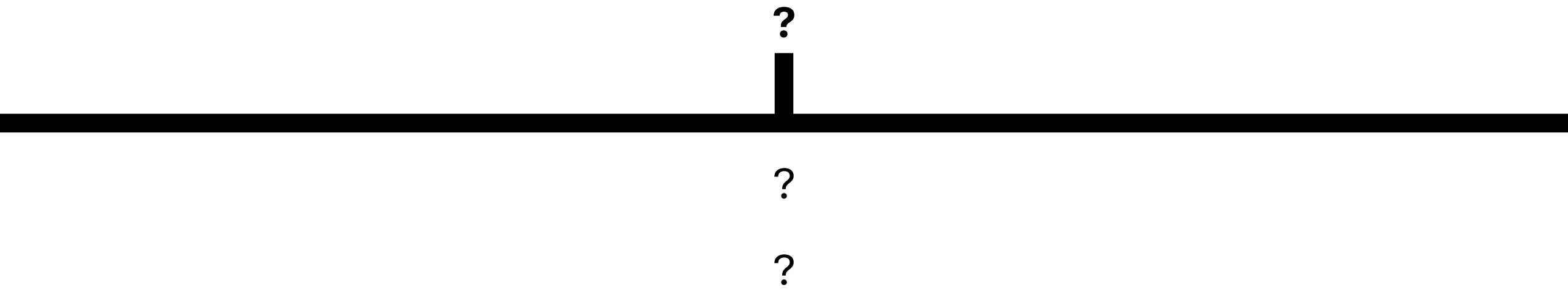
History of Canon Discussion

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History of Canon Discussion



Class 4:
Modern Canonical Models

Based on:
(1) M. Kruger, *Canon Revisited: Establishing the Origins and Authority of the New Testament Books*, Crossway (2012)
(2) M. Kruger, *The Origin & Authority of New Testament Canon*, YouTube Lecture Series

Download Slides

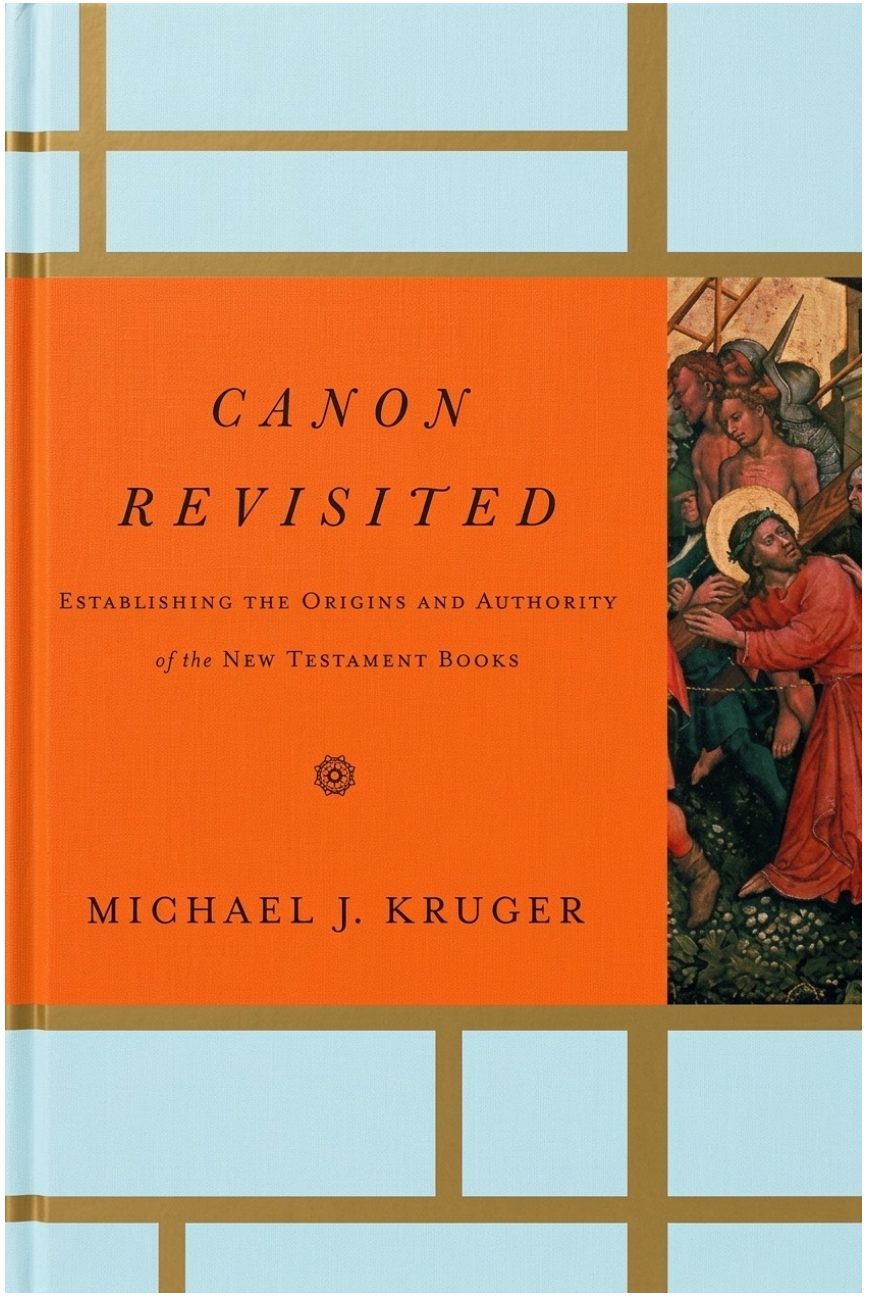
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Sources

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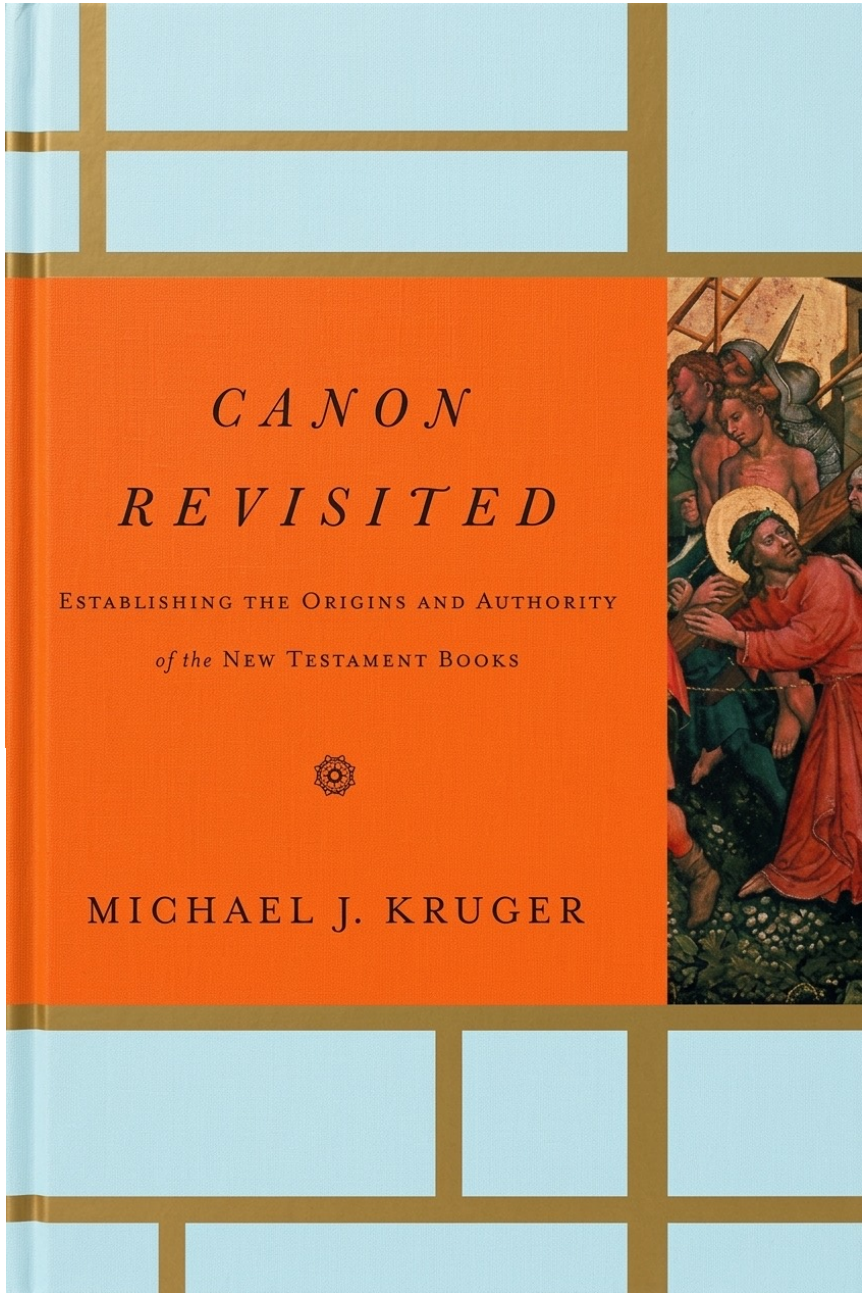
- Canon discussed for a Christian audience, not for debating skeptics
  - “Nor, as we discussed in the introduction, are we attempting to somehow “prove” to the skeptic (in a way that would satisfy him) that these books are indeed from God. Rather, the question before us is whether the Christian faith, with its twenty-seven-book New Testament, can give an adequate account for how it can be known that these books are canonical” (p. 92)

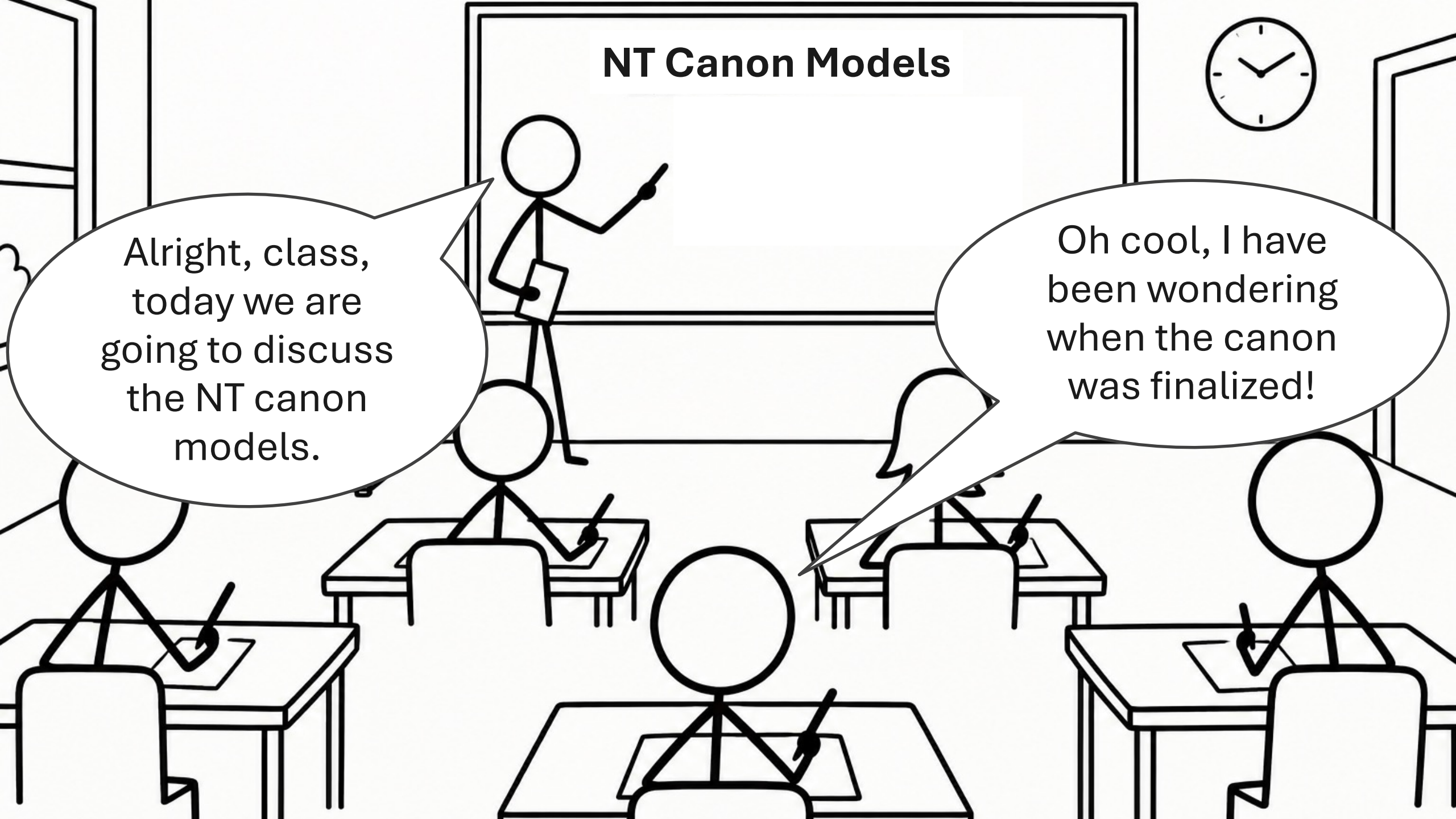


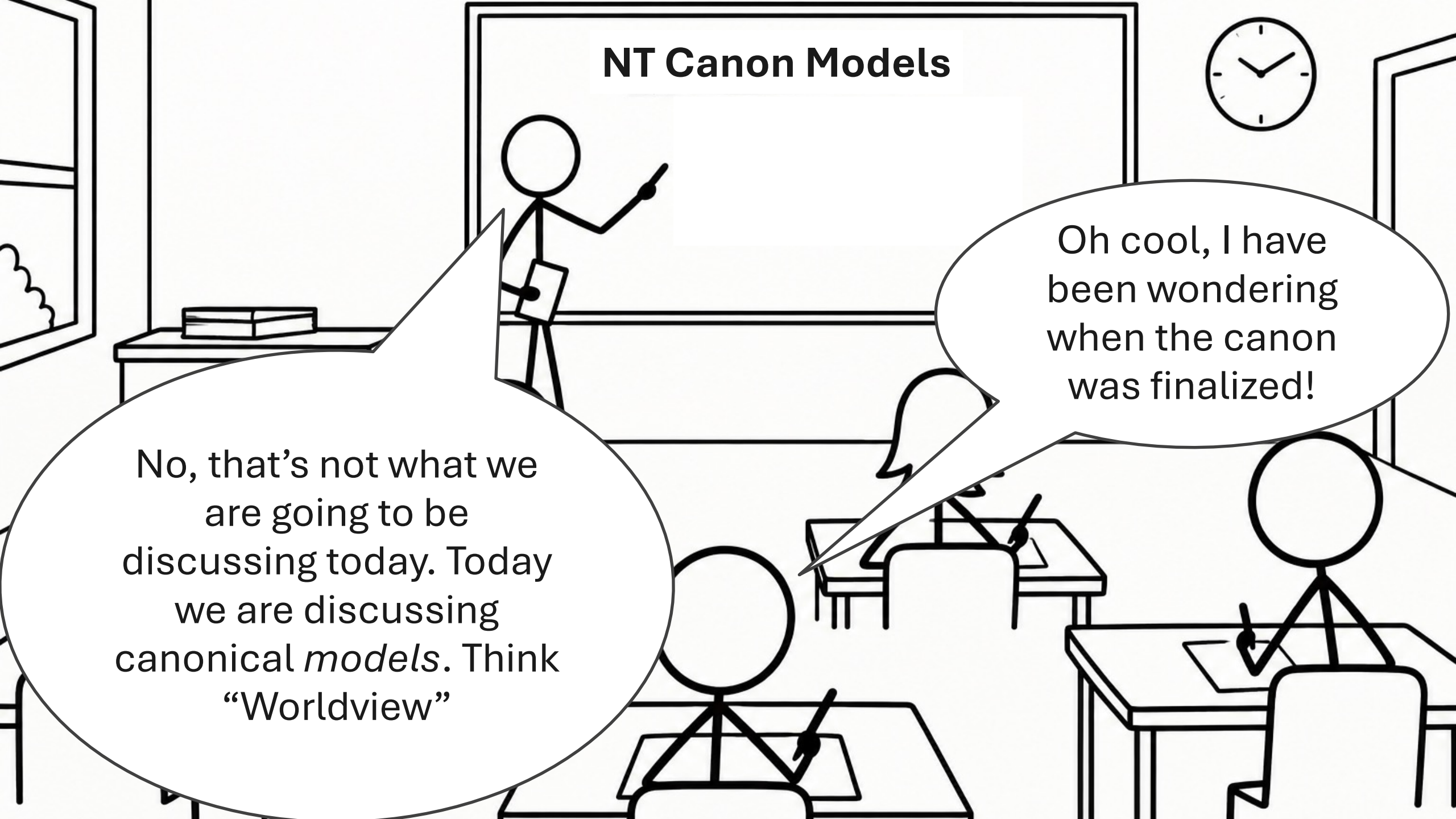
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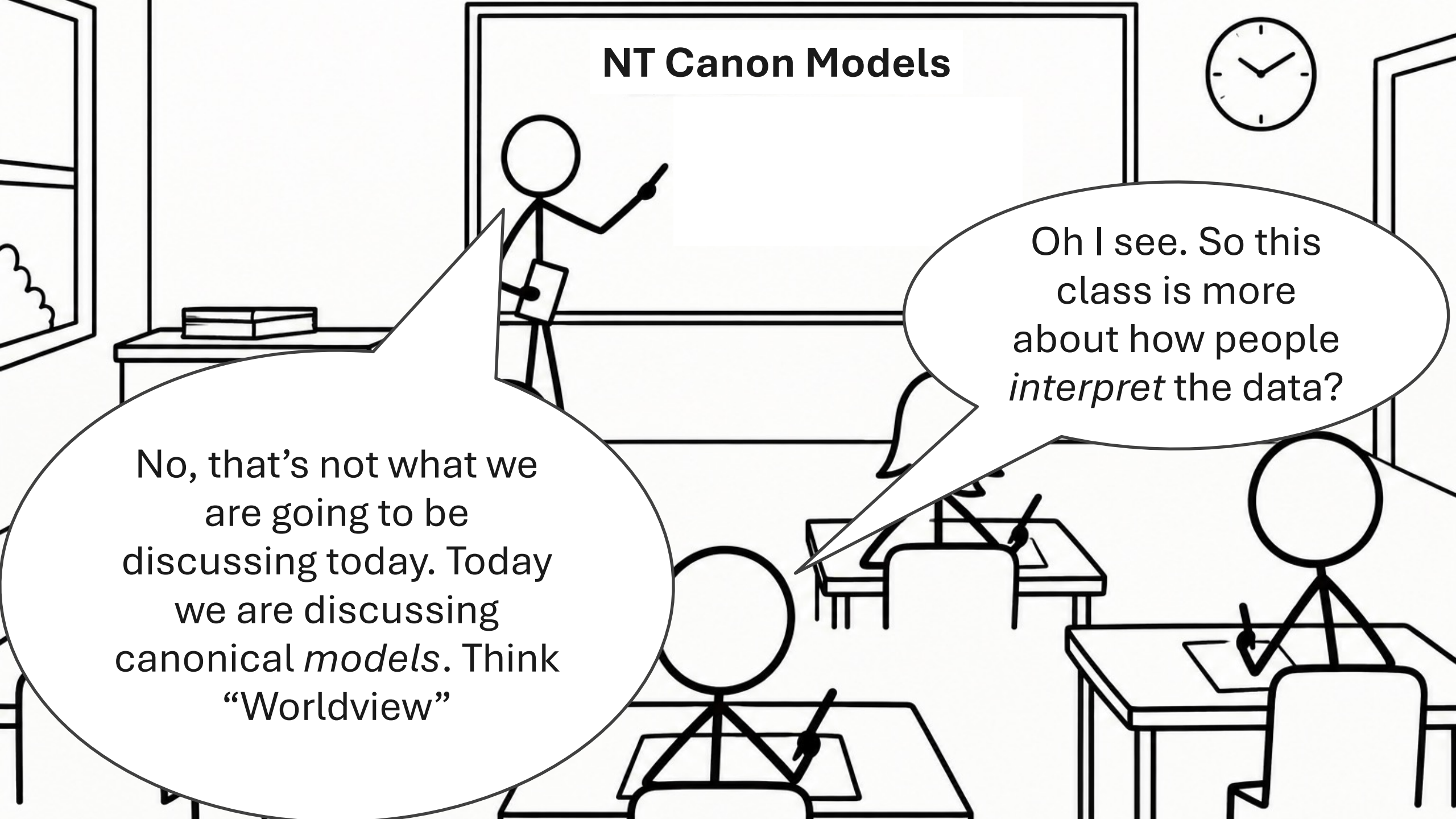
- *Canon Revisited* by Michael J. Kruger

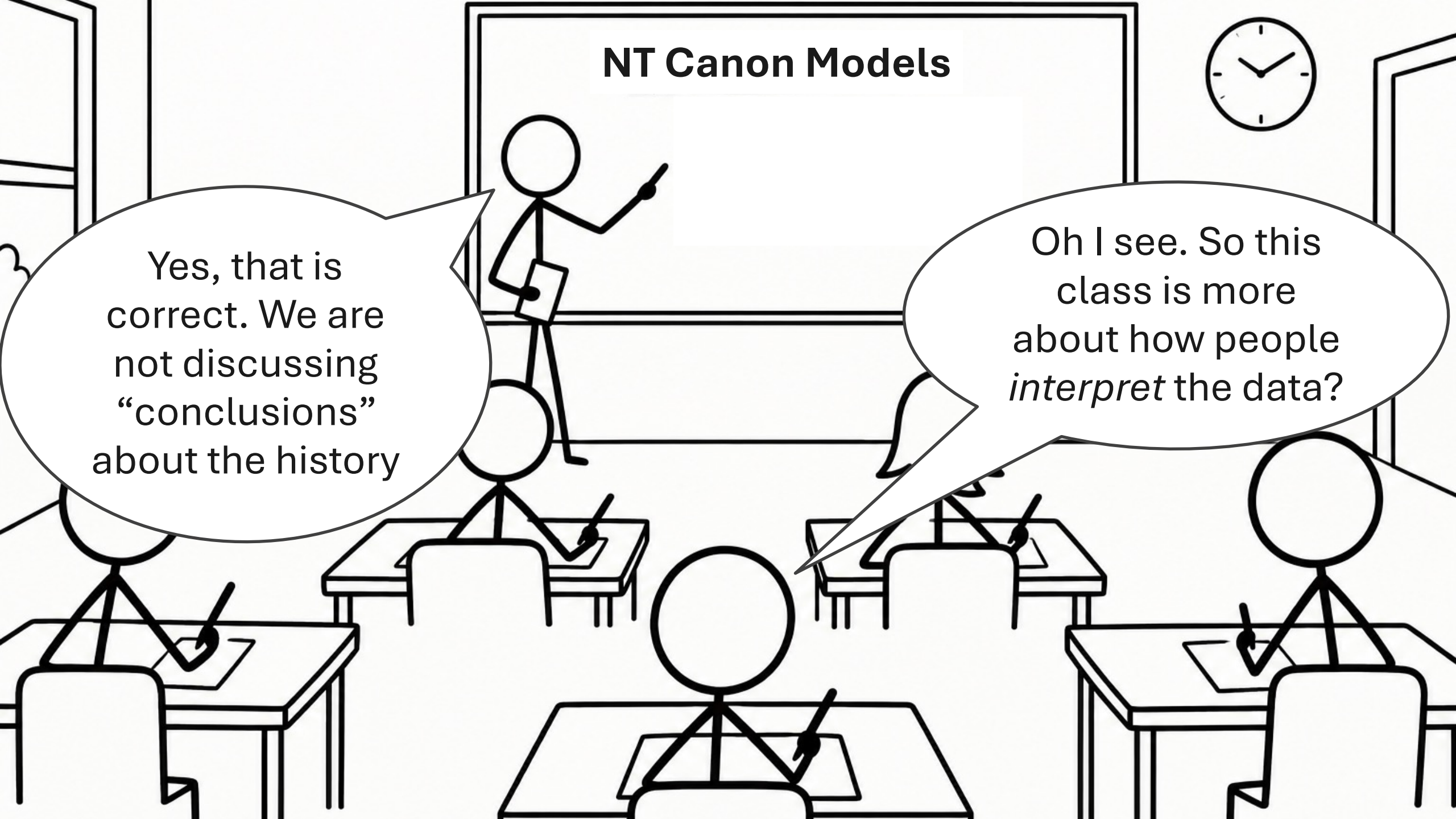
- YouTube Lecture Series from Michael J. Kruger: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SUvJQmduAdA&list=PLzytIUBlFDMN62nZiv6cPVBYoBaCPJjQM

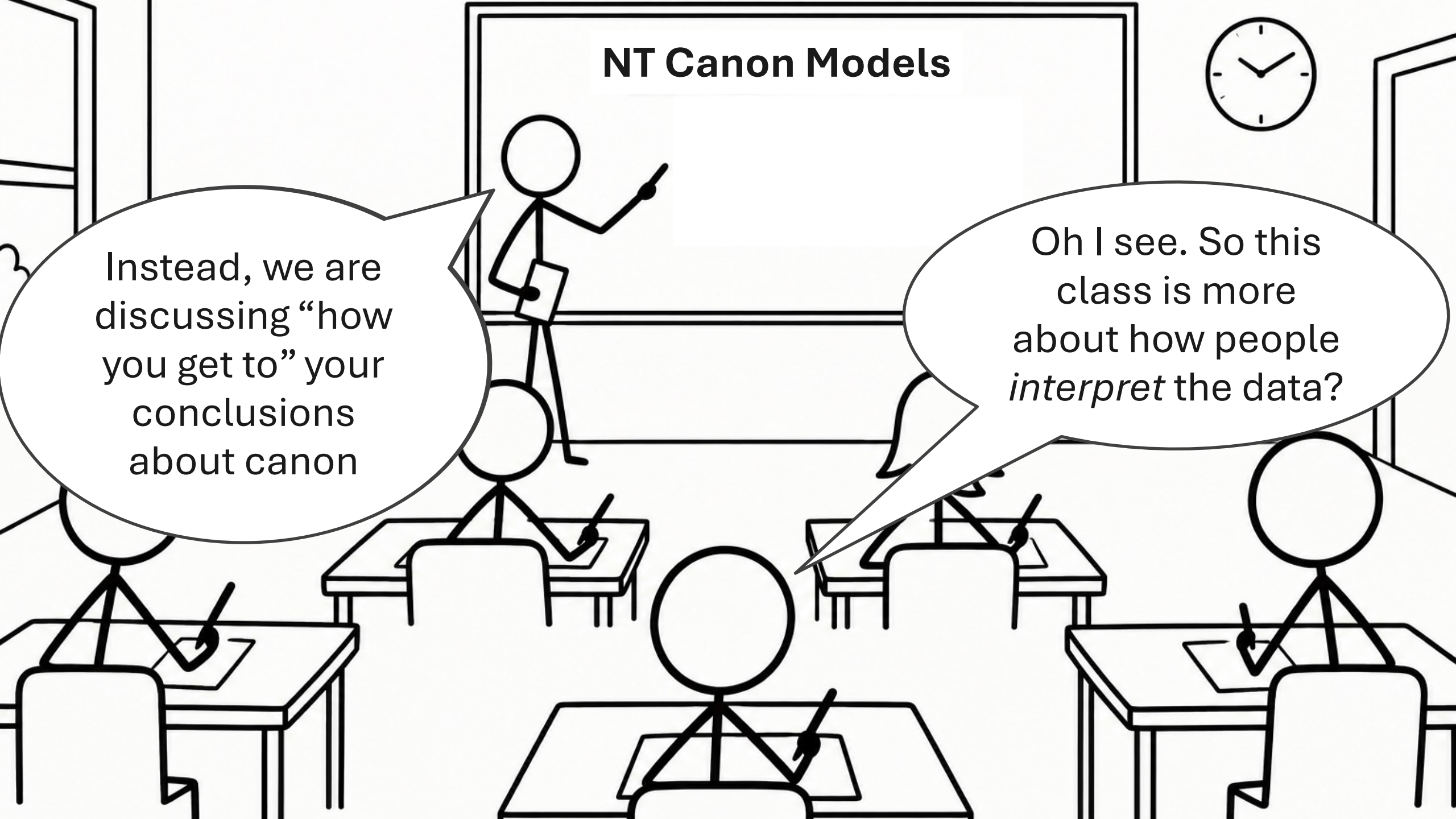


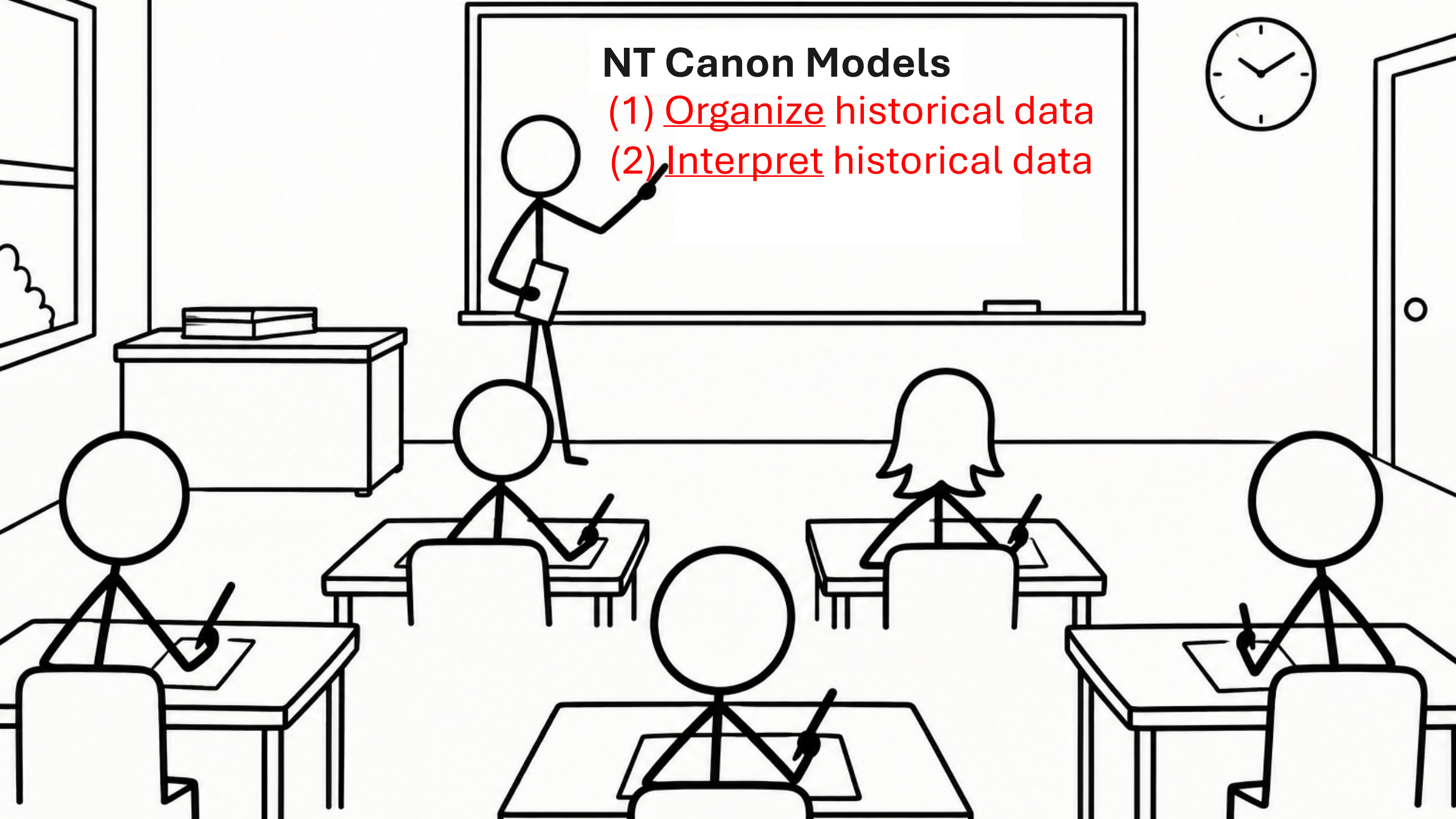

NT Canon Models
Alright, class, today we are going to discuss the NT canon models.
Oh cool, I have been wondering when the canon was finalized!

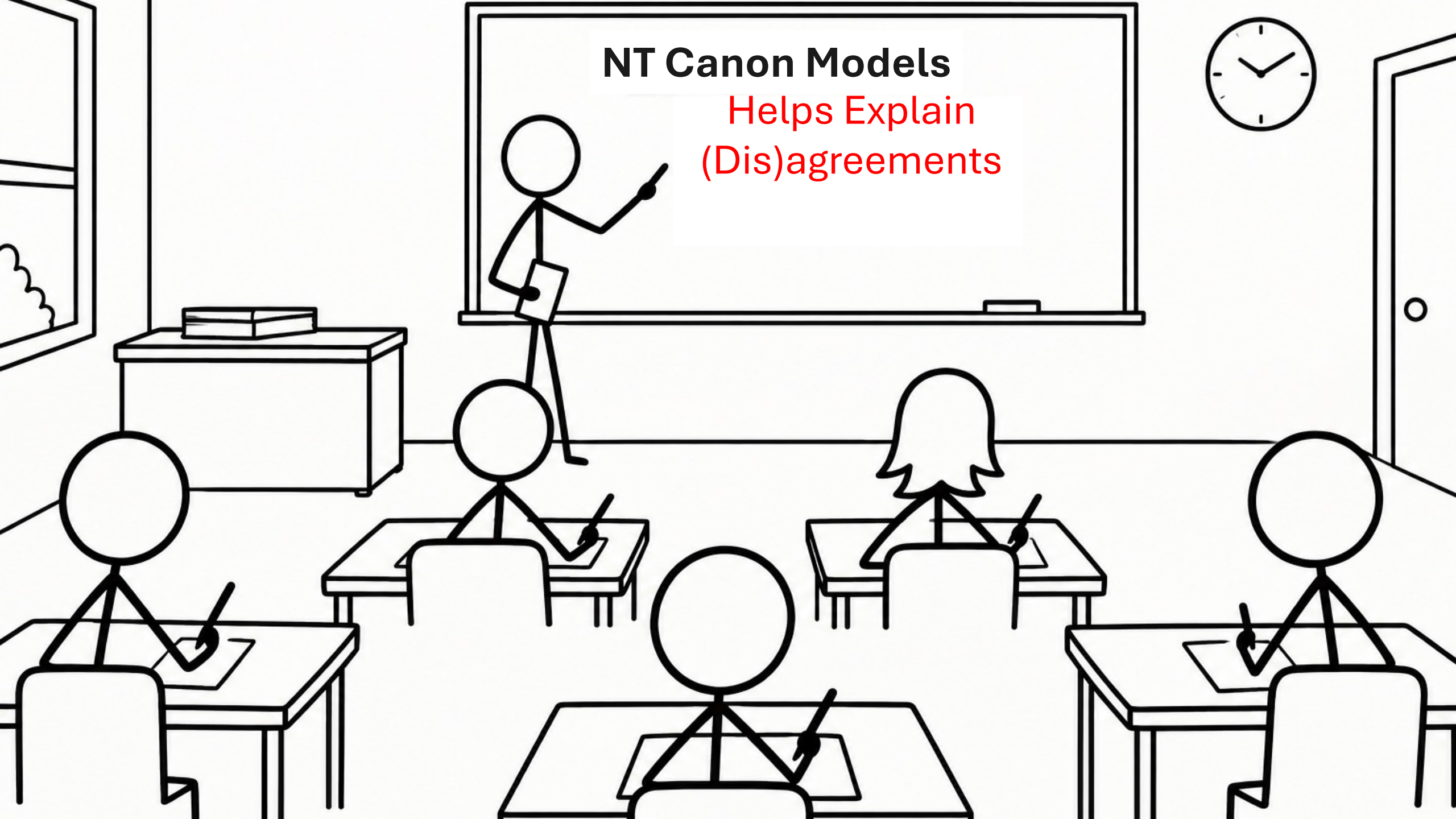

NT Canon Models
No, that’s not what we are going to be discussing today. Today we are discussing canonical *models*. Think “Worldview”
Oh cool, I have been wondering when the canon was finalized!

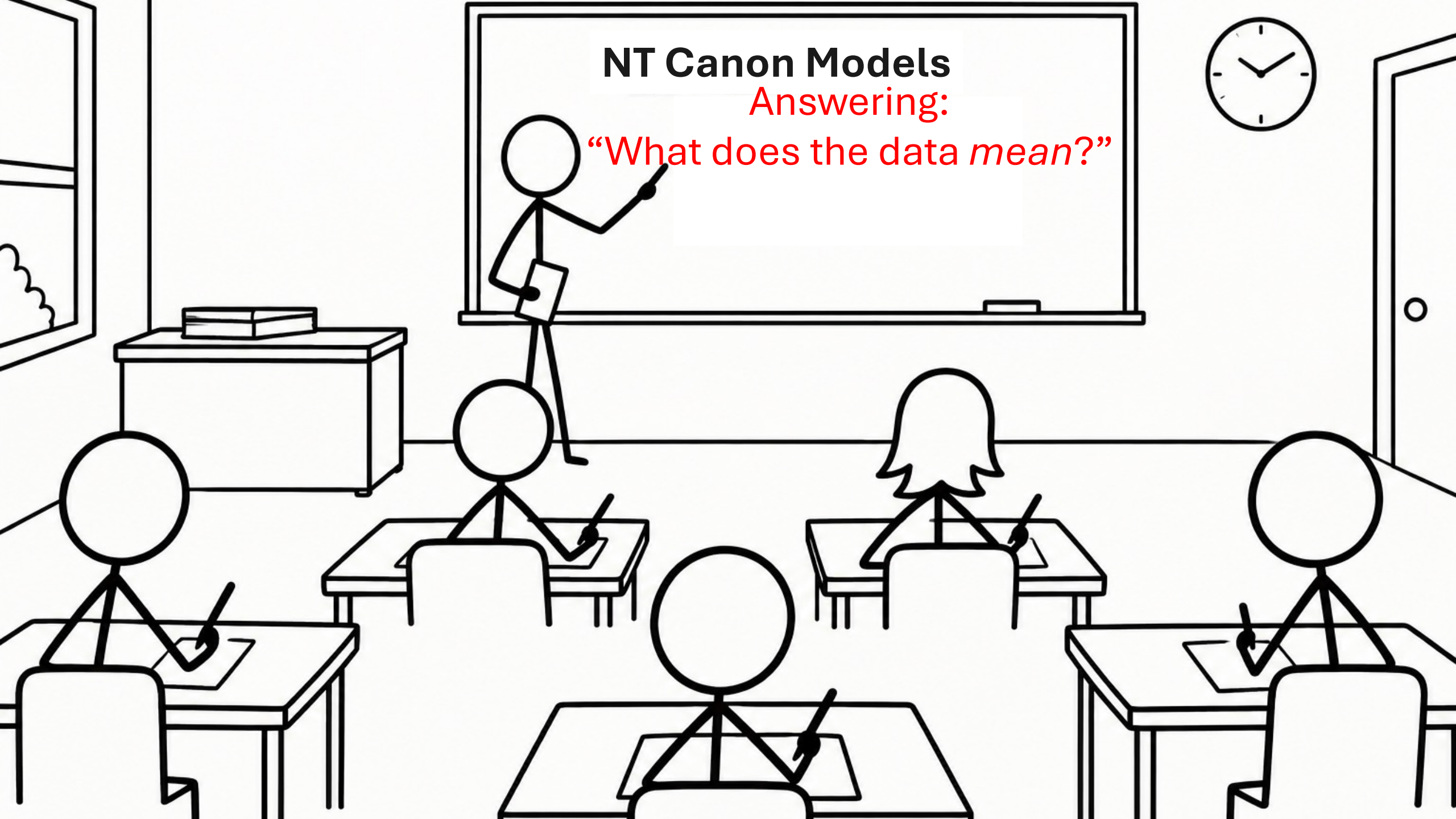

NT Canon Models
No, that’s not what we are going to be discussing today. Today we are discussing canonical *models*. Think “Worldview”
Oh I see. So this class is more about how people *interpret* the data?


NT Canon Models
Yes, that is correct. We are not discussing "conclusions" about the history
Oh I see. So this class is more about how people *interpret* the data?


NT Canon Models
Instead, we are discussing “how you get to” your conclusions about canon
Oh I see. So this class is more about how people *interpret* the data?


NT Canon Models
(1) Organize historical data
(2) Interpret historical data


NT Canon Models
Helps Explain
(Dis)agreements

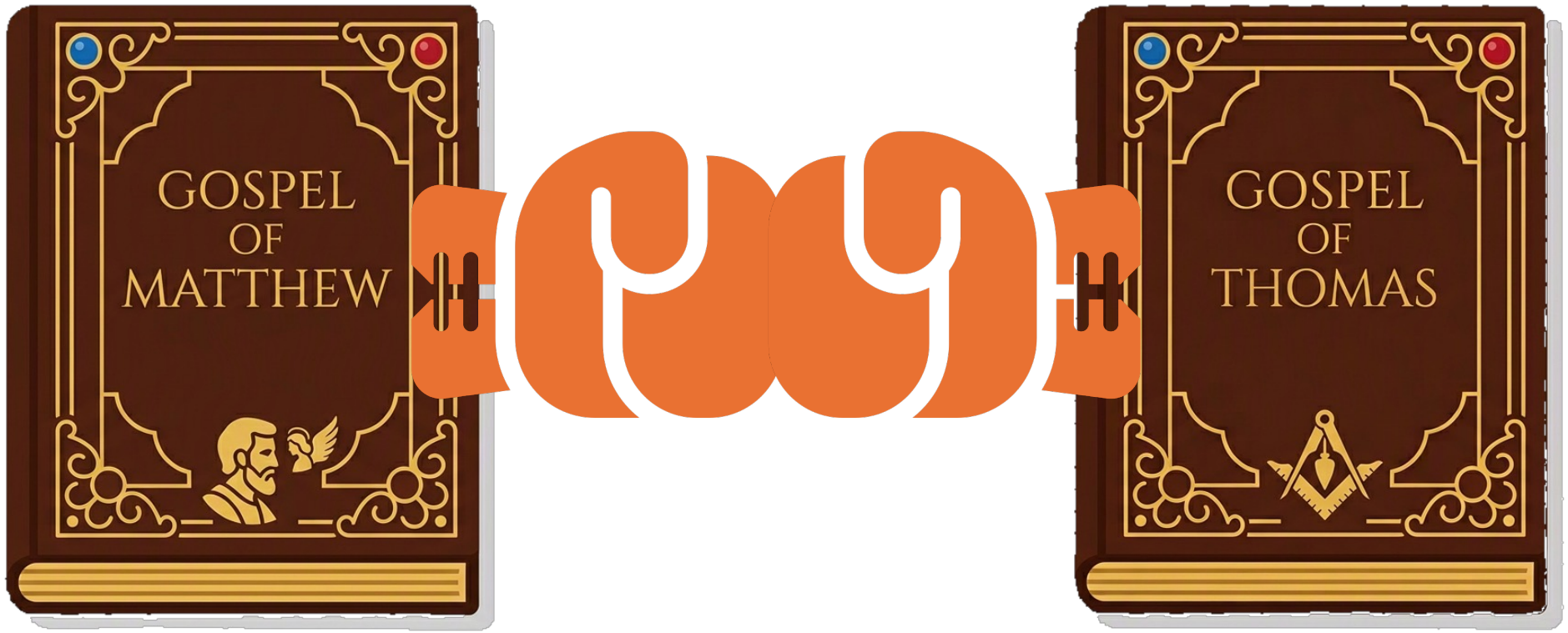

NT Canon Models
Answering:
“What does the data *mean*?”

1. Historical-Critical Model

Historical-Critical Model

- “Scholars have argued that the idea of a canon, with its particular boundaries, is simply (or largely) the product of human activities within the church during the early centuries of Christianity” (p. 30)
- “Thus, canon is just a social phenomenon that arises when a community desires to express its identity” (p. 31)
- “Bauer argues that there was no “orthodoxy” or “heresy” within earliest Christianity, but rather there were various “Christianities,” each competing for dominance. Thus, says Bauer, the New Testament canon we possess is nothing more than the books chosen by the eventual theological winners—a historical accident, so to speak” (p. 32)

Historical-Critical Model



Historical-Critical Model



Historical-Critical Model Evaluation

- “the historical-critical model is correct to remind us of the role of the Christian community in the formation of the New Testament canon…. That being said, however, the fundamental problem with the historical-critical model is not its affirmation that the church played a role, but rather its insistence that the church played the determinative and decisive role. Quickly swept aside are any claims that these books contain any intrinsic authority that might have been a factor in their reception” (pp. 34-35)

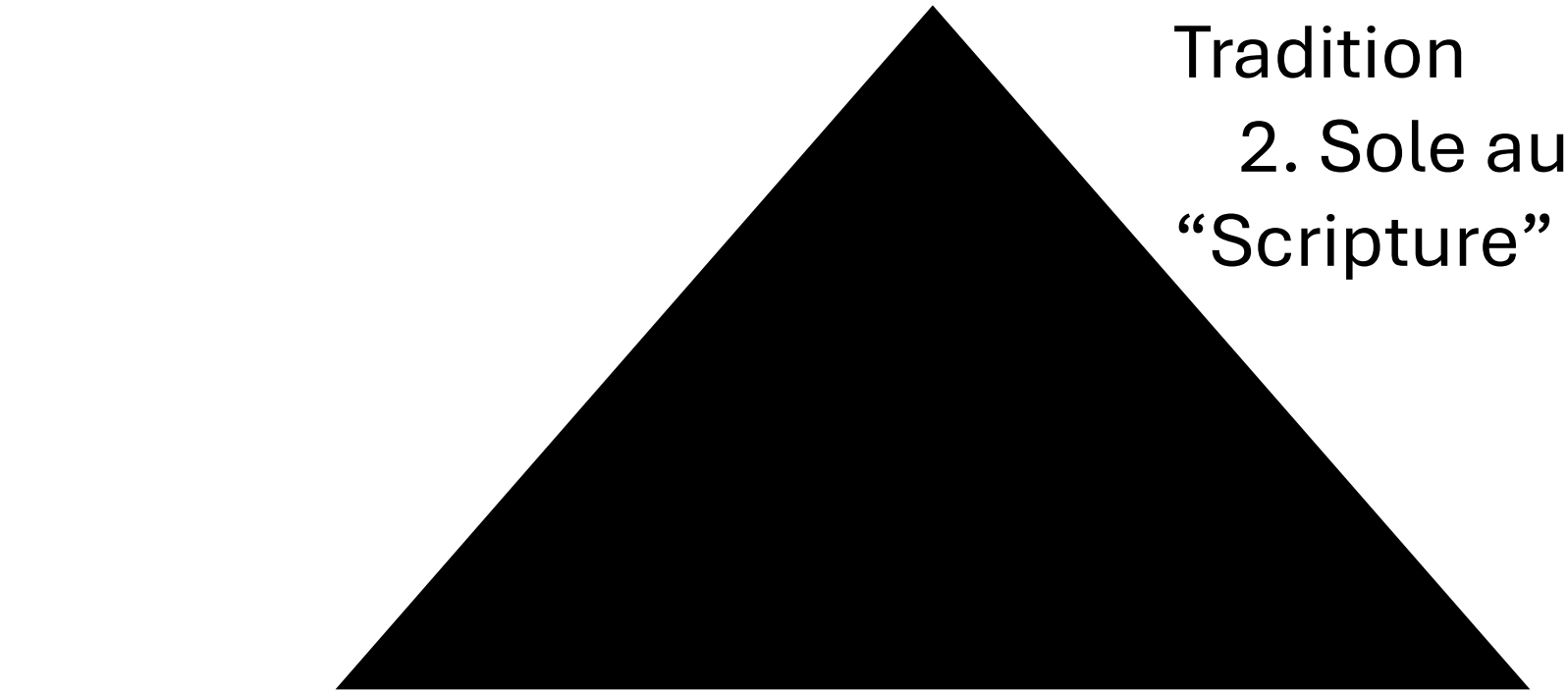
- “simply demonstrating some human involvement in the canonical process is not sufficient to demonstrate *sole* human involvement. The fact that proximate, human decisions played a role in the development of the canon does not rule out the possibility that ultimate, divine activity also played a role. The two are not mutually exclusive” (p. 35)

1. Historical-Critical Model = Boxing Match
2. Roman Catholic Model

Roman Catholic Model

- “At the core of the Roman Catholic view of canon is Rome’s view of the authority of Scripture. Roman Catholicism denies that ultimate authority exists in the Scriptures alone (*sola scriptura*) and has consequently adopted the well-known trifold authority structure that includes Scripture, tradition, and the Magisterium (the church’s teaching authority)” (pp. 38–39)

Roman Catholic Model



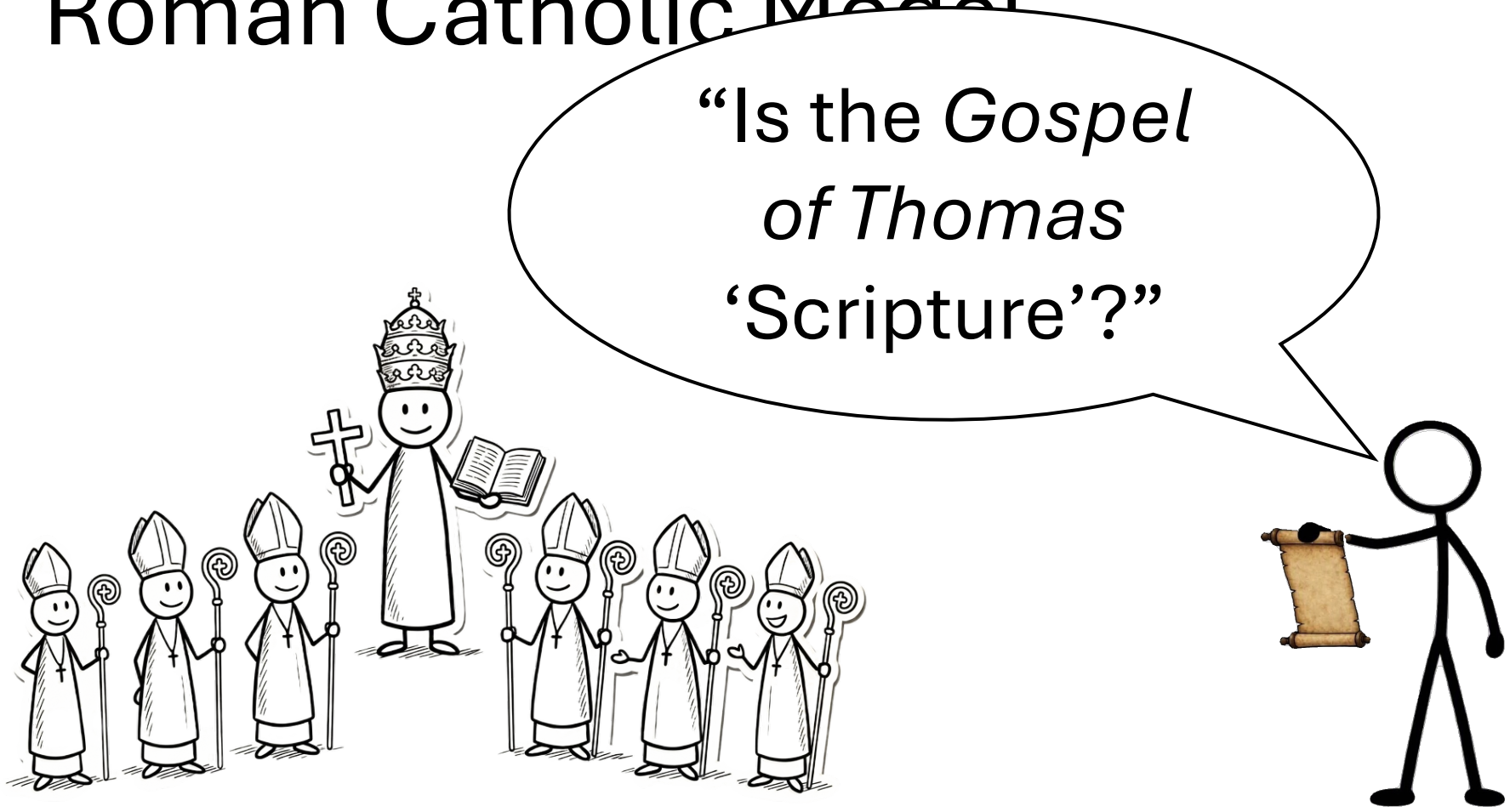
= 1. Interprets Scripture and Tradition

2. Sole authority to define "Scripture" and "Tradition"

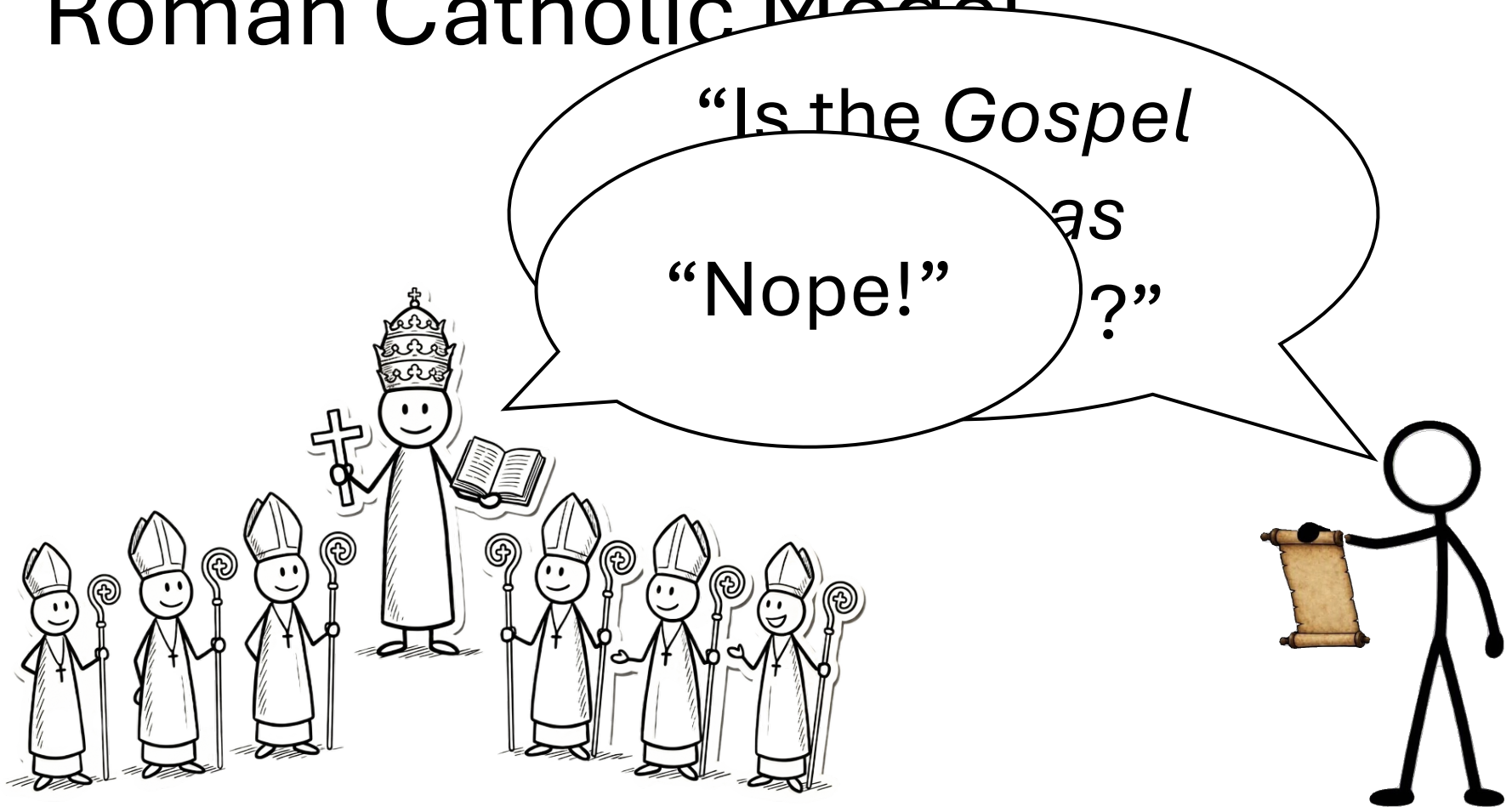
Roman Catholic Model



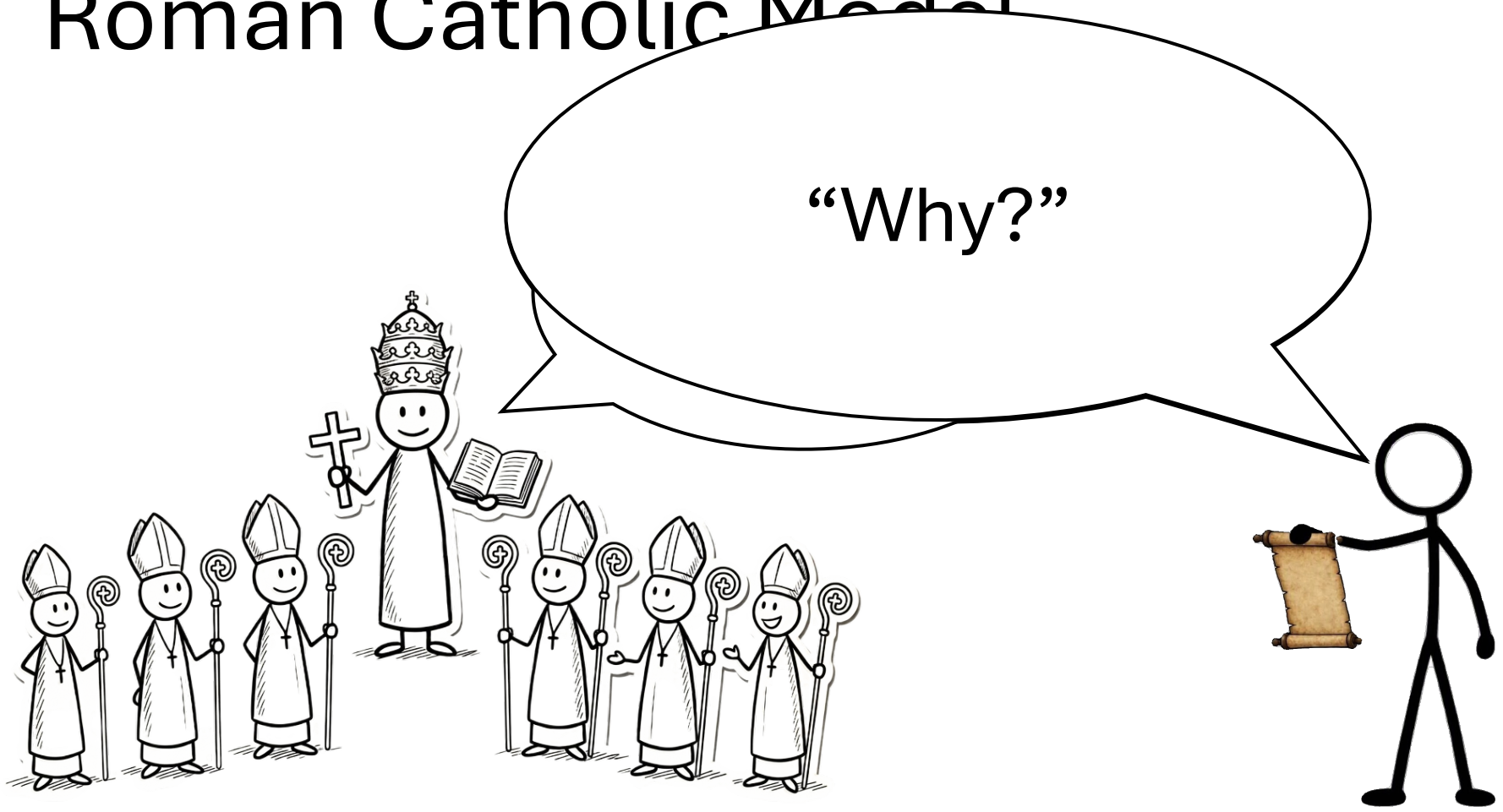
Roman Catholic Model



Roman Catholic Model



Roman Catholic Model



Roman Catholic Model



Roman Catholic Model

- “H. J. Adriaanse observes, ‘Catholic Theology … has solved the canon problem with a plea to the authority of the Church’” (p. 39)
- “Thus, the canon is ultimately community determined. The fundamental challenge from Roman Catholicism is that in order to have an infallible Scripture, we need to have an infallible guide (namely, the church) to tell us what is, and what is not, Scripture” (pp. 39–40)
- “Karl Rahner asserts, ‘[Scripture] exists because the church exists’” (p. 40)
- “the term *canon* is often used simply to refer to the books that functioned as an authoritative ‘norm’ or standard for the Christian community, that is, as Scripture” (p. 40)
- Belief the NT books are inspired and ”Thus, Joseph Lienhard… [declares] that ‘about 180 [AD], there is a New Testament’ and ‘a New Testament exists when a collection of Christian writings is generally accepted in the church as equal in authority to the Jewish Scriptures” (p. 40)

Roman Catholic Model Evaluation

- Different conceptions in this model:

1. "The church not as creating or constituting the canon, but merely as recognizing the authority of the canon that was already there" (p. 41)
   - "The church's role is primarily epistemological—it is the sole and fundamental means by which we infallibly *know* which books belong in the canon" (p. 41)
   - "The Bible is in the Church, but *not from the Church*" (Lienhard as qtd on p. 41)
2. "The church not simply as the means by which the canon is infallibly recognized (although it does affirm this), but as, in some sense, the foundation or the grounds for the canon" (p. 42)
   - "We 'derive the essence of the Scripture from the essence of the church' and therefore the Scripture is 'derivative' from the church and 'an act of the Church'" (Rahner as qtd on p. 42)
   - "Peter Kreeft…argues that the church 'caused' the canon because it preceded the canon" (p. 42)
   - "Hans Küng…: 'Without the Church there would be no New Testament" (p. 42)

Roman Catholic Model Evaluation

1. “The church not as creating or constituting the canon, but merely as recognizing the authority of the canon that was already there” (p. 41)
   - Claims that without the RCC, there is *no way of knowing* which books belong in the canon
   - “If only Christians had…[an] inspired table of contents, then we would not need the authoritative rulings of the Roman Catholic Church to authenticate the canon” (p. 42)
- The issue here:
   - How does one know that this “inspired table of contents” is really inspired? Wouldn’t the RCC need to confirm that too!

Roman Catholic Model Evaluation

1. “The church not as creating or constituting the canon, but merely as recognizing the authority of the canon that was already there” (p. 41)
   - “The problem, then, is not that the church plays a role in identifying canonical books (Protestants would agree with this), but the Catholic insistence that it plays the *only* and *definitive* role” (p. 44)

Roman Catholic Model Evaluation

2. “The church not simply as the means by which the canon is infallibly recognized (although it does affirm this), but as, in some sense, the foundation or the grounds for the canon” (p. 42)
   - But the apostolic teachings are the foundation of the church, not the other way around (cf. Eph 2:20)!
   - Chapman: “The biblical canon is not a creation of the church, the church is instead a creation of the biblical canon” (qtd on p. 44)
   - Paul’s writings were authoritative before the RCC! (cf. 1 Thess 2:13, Gal 1:1-24, 2 Peter 3:16)
   - The Council of Trent (1546) was the RCC’s official declaration of the canon. No canon before that?

Roman Catholic Model Evaluation

2. “The church not simply as the means by which the canon is infallibly recognized (although it does affirm this), but as, in some sense, the foundation or the grounds for the canon” (p. 42)
    - J. I. Parker: “The Church no more gave us the New Testament canon than Sir Isaac Newton gave us the force of gravity. God gave us gravity … Newton did not create gravity but recognized it” (qtd on p. 45)

Roman Catholic Model Evaluation

- The problem with RCM: confuses the instruments God used to produce the Bible (humans) and God's work to make the canon
- The NT canon is not the production of the church but of God, recognized by the church

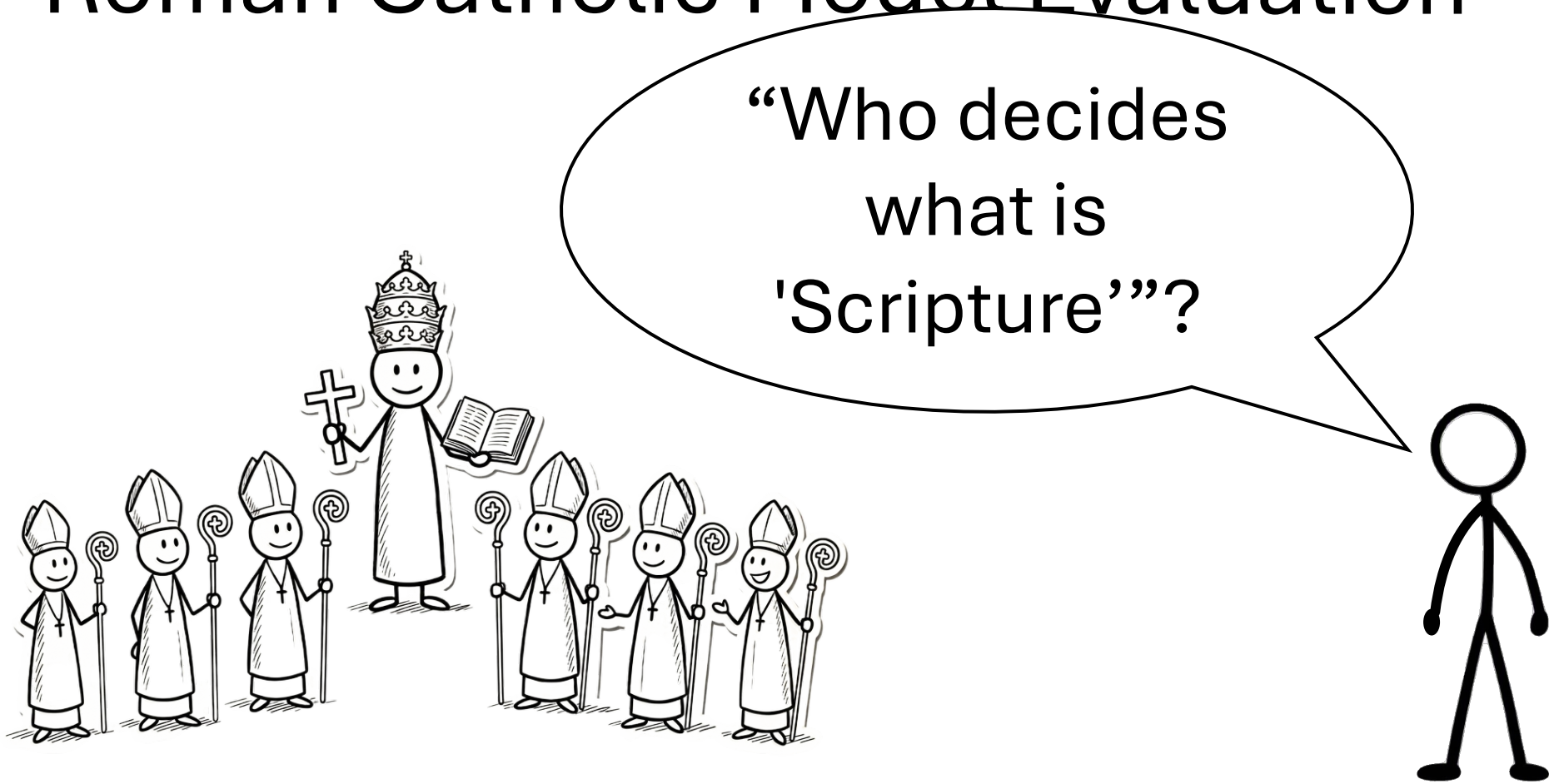
Roman Catholic Model Evaluation

- Where does RCC get its authority from?
  1. From the Scriptures? That is circular reasoning!
  2. From history? But those aren't *infallible* grounds
  3. Only logical answer: "the church's authority is self-authenticating and needs no external authority to validate it" (p. 47)

Roman Catholic Model Evaluation



Roman Catholic Model Evaluation



Roman Catholic Model Evaluation



Roman Catholic Model Evaluation



Roman Catholic Model Evaluation



1. Historical-Critical Model = Boxing Match
2. Roman Catholic Model

1. Historical-Critical Model = Boxing Match
2. Roman Catholic Model = Church Created
3. Canonical-Critical Model

Canonical-Critical Model

- Started with OT scholars Brevard Childs and James Sanders (then expanded to NT)
- “Childs argues that the meaning of the biblical text is not best found by trying to discover its earliest ‘layer’ via form criticism, source criticism, or redaction criticism—the standard tools of modern critical scholarship—but the meaning of a text is bound up with how the text functions within its larger canonical context. In other words, contrary to popular perceptions, the text is best understood not at its earliest stage of literary development (after the scholar peels back the various layers), but in its latest stage of literary development, when it has taken its final shape.... Thus, the central tenet of canonical criticism (at least according to Childs) is that only the final canonical form of the text embraced by the early church is the proper ground for biblical theology and exegesis” (p. 49)

Canonical-Critical Model

- “Childs has argued that our canonical texts have undergone significant development throughout the canonical process as successive Christian generations not only chose writings, but have shaped, modified, and redacted these writings. Such a view broadens the activity of inspiration by moving it beyond its traditional locale—in the ‘apostles and prophets’—and expanding it to include the overall ecclesiastical community” (pp. 52-53)

Canonical-Critical Model

- **2 factors driving this theory:**
  1. “Childs argues that it is only the final form of the New Testament canon that brings together the divergent (and often contradictory) streams of early Christianity and provides a larger framework in which they can be understood and even harmonized” (p. 50)
     - “In other words, the theological struggle among the early factions of Christianity is what shaped, formed, and molded the canon as we know it; to ignore the final form of the canon in favor of its earliest layer is to ignore all the factors that went into shaping it and thus is to ignore the real ‘historical’ aspect of canon” (p. 50)
  2. “The final form of the New Testament should be normative because the final redactors who put the New Testament together intentionally shaped the material into a medium that would allow it to be transmitted to future generations” (p. 50)

Canonical-Critical Model

- **2 factors driving this theory:**

1. Final form = the final, official form shaped by the struggles during pre-canonical state

2. Final form = form redactors made for future generations

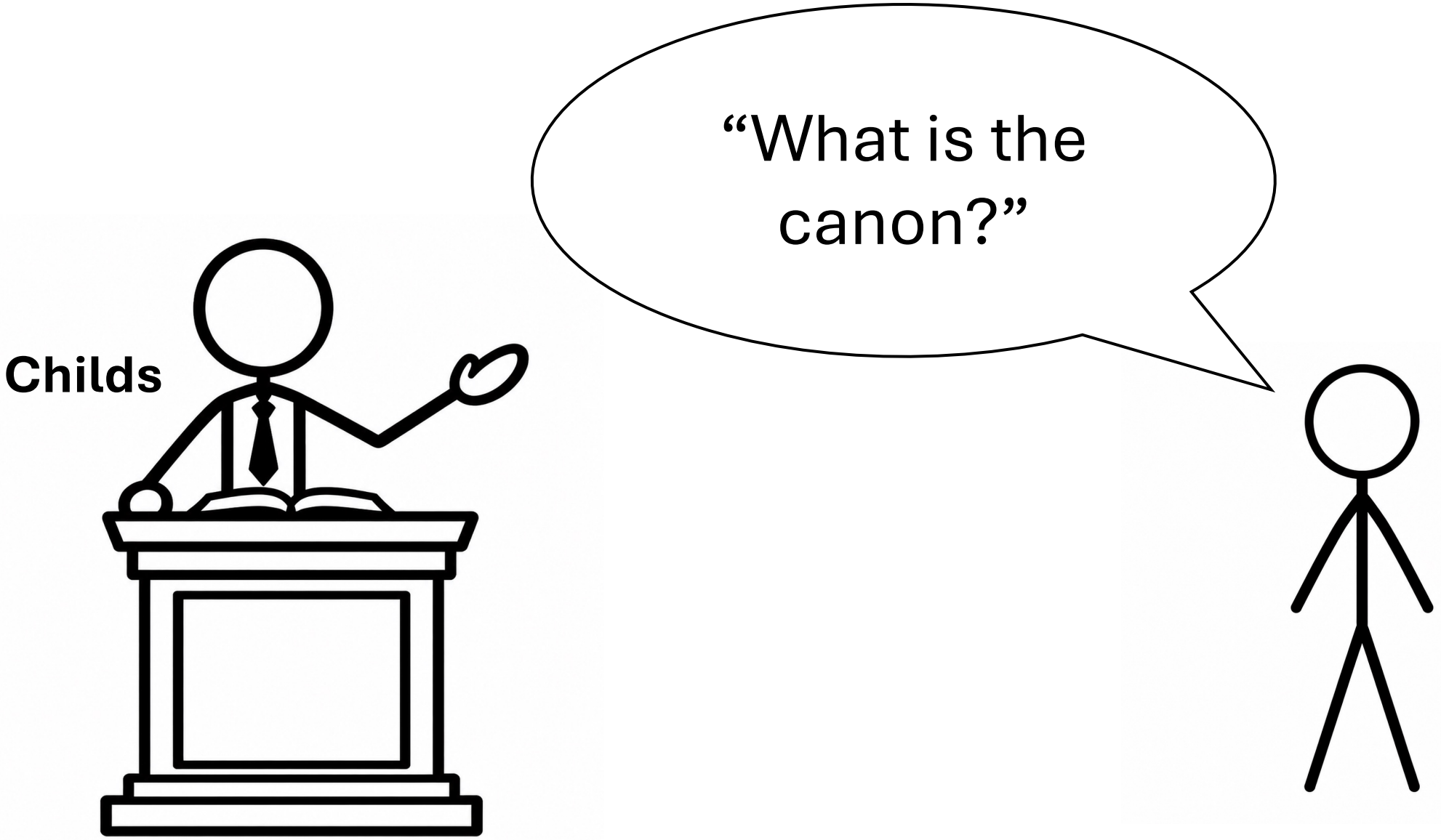
Canonical-Critical Model

- “Childs’s approach, then, would reject the historical-critical notion that the idea of a canon is merely ‘a late, ecclesiastical activity, external to the biblical literature itself, which was subsequently imposed on those writings.’ On the contrary, Childs would affirm that the church’s ‘canonical consciousness’ was there from the beginning and ‘lies deep within the New Testament literature itself’” (p. 51)
- “By now it is clear how Childs’s canonical-criticism model determines which books should be included in the canon. It consists of the books (and the shape of those books) finally settled upon and received by the early church as the basis for their understanding of the gospel. Even so, Childs does not restrict the technical term *canon* to only this final stage” (p. 51)

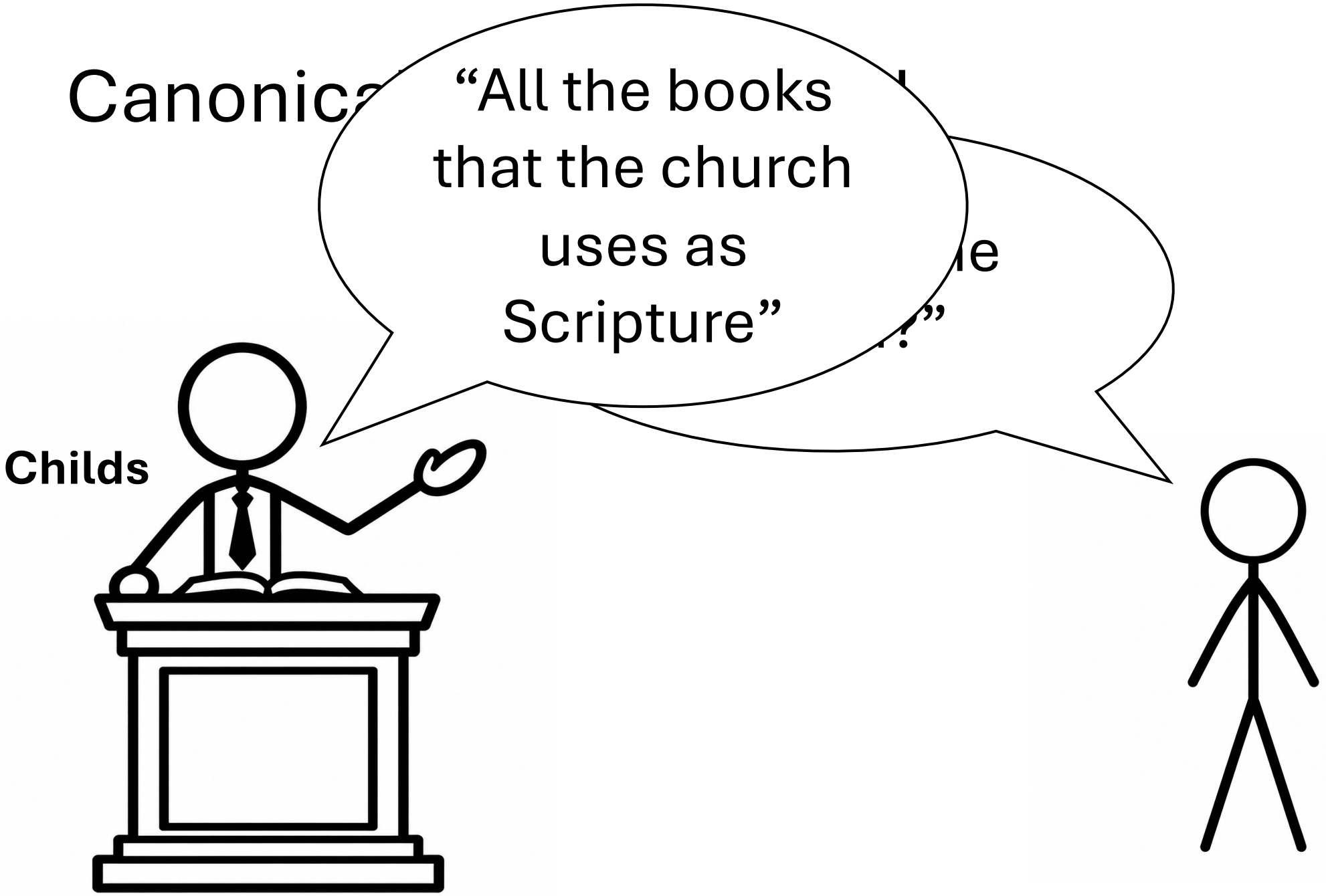
Canonical-Critical Model

- “Instead of merely denoting a closed list, Childs and others have suggested that the term can refer to a collection of books that constitutes a religious norm for a community (regardless of whether the collection is ‘open’ or ‘closed’). A canon would exist, on this definition, when there is evidence that books are functioning as Scripture. James Sanders agrees: “Canon as *function* antedates canon as *shape*” (p. 52)

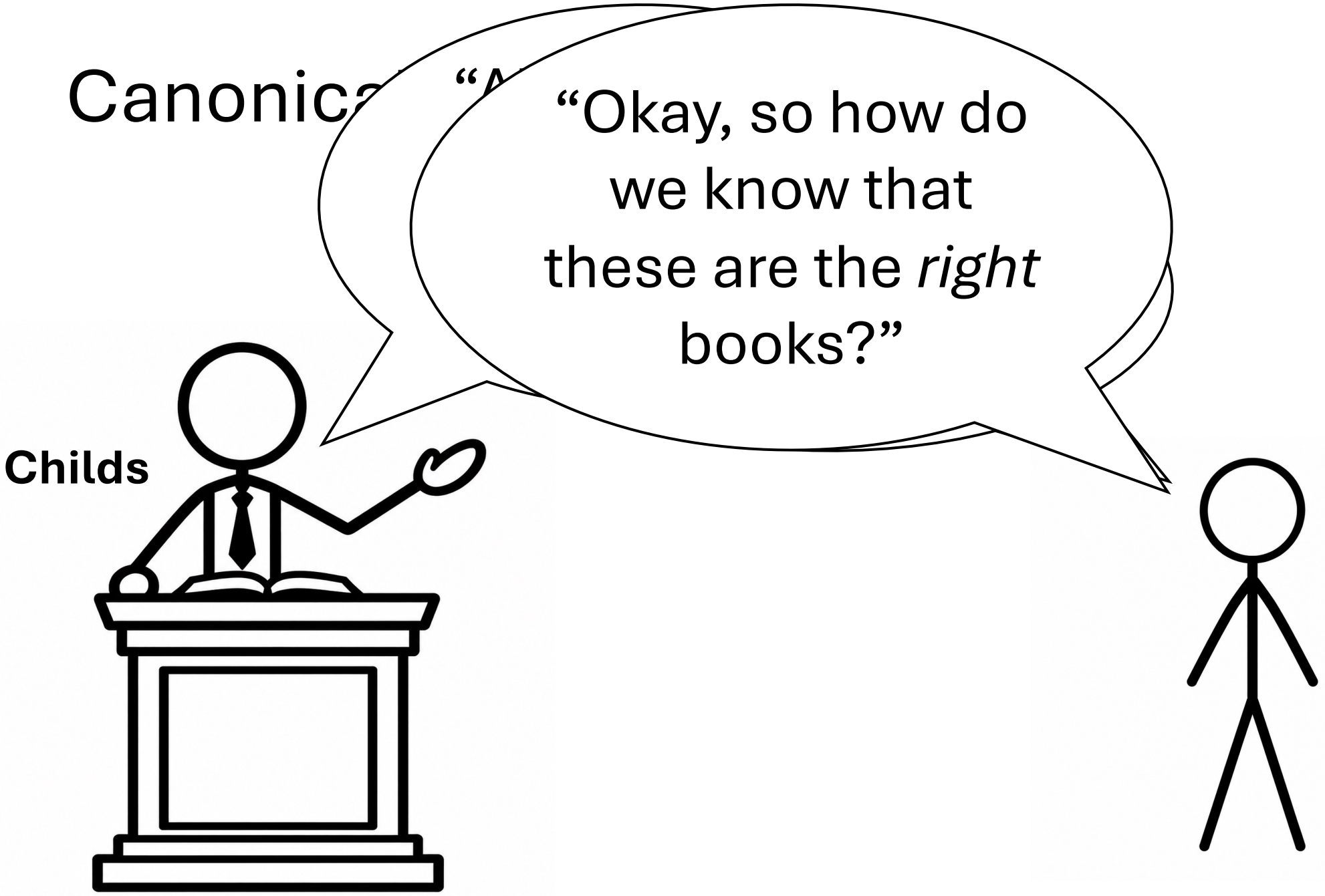
Canonical-Critical Model



Canonica



Canonica



Canonica

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Canonical-Critical Model

Historical-Critical Method

“We want to figure out this!”

“What is the *earliest* layer of the text?”

1st century AD — **4th century AD**

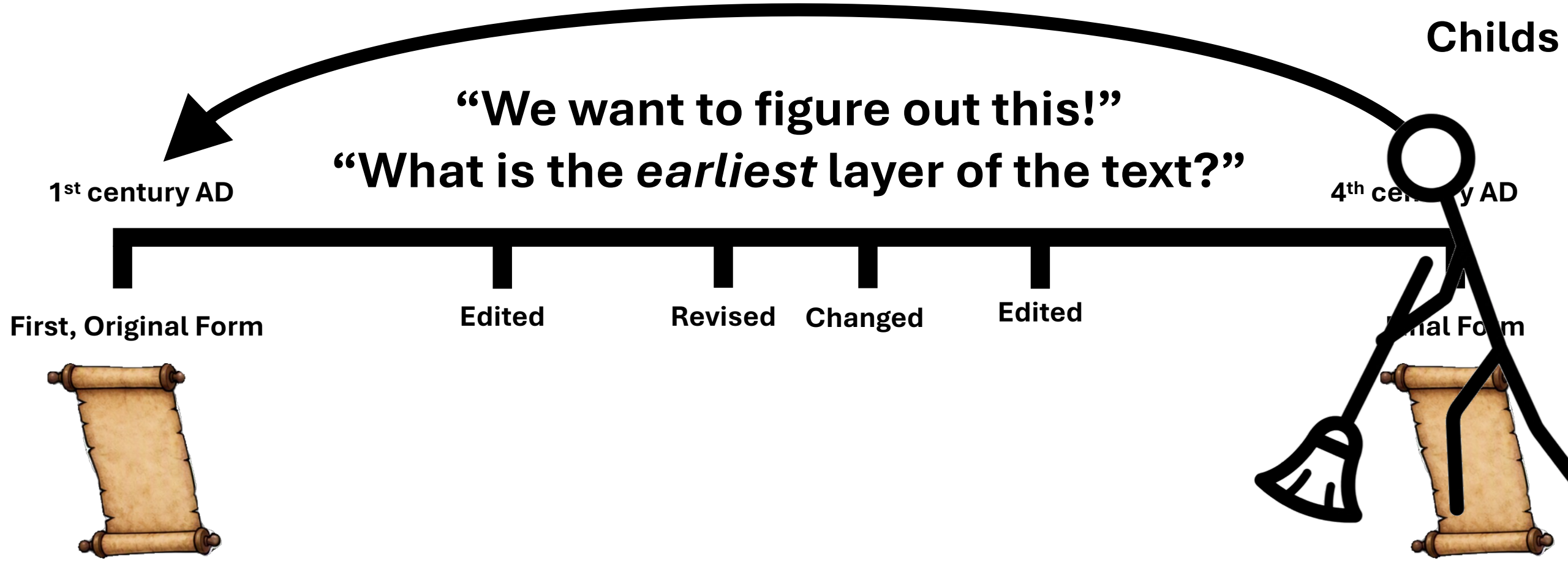
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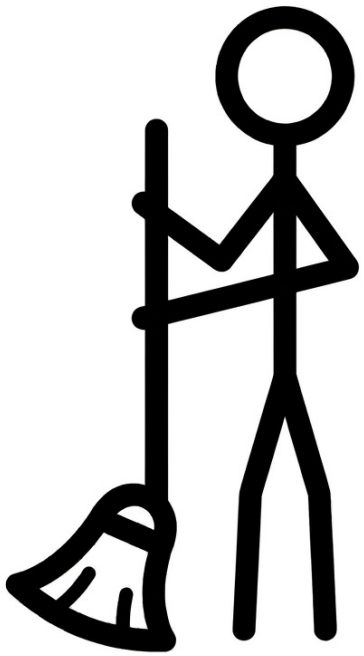
Canonical-Critical Model

Historical-Critical Method



Canonical-Critical Model

Childs



1st century AD — **4th century AD**

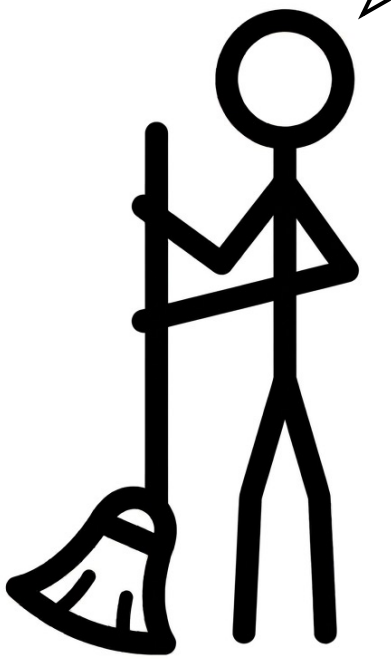
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“This is the form we want! We don’t need to look for the ‘first form’”

Childs



1st century AD

4th century AD

First, Original Form

Edited

Revised

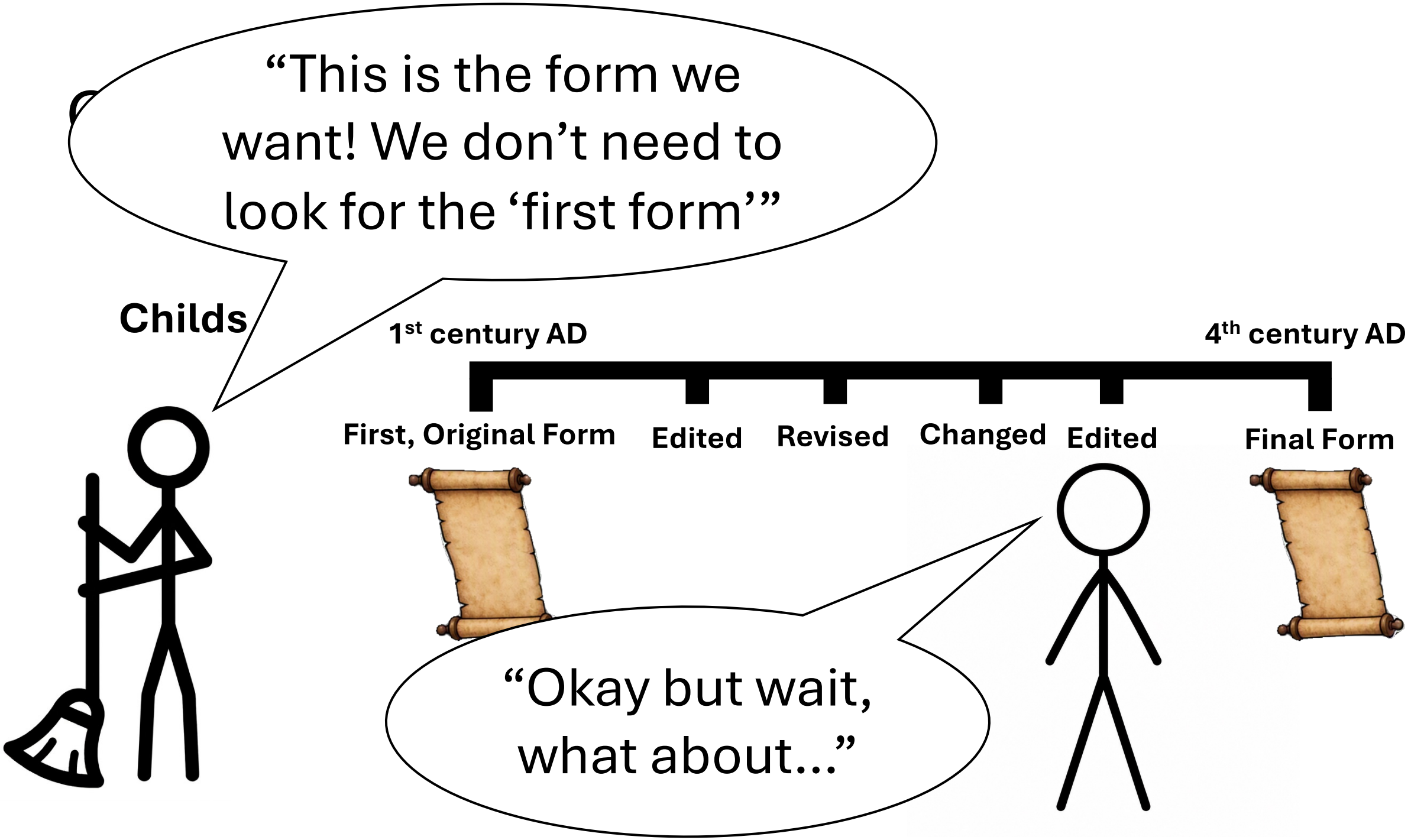
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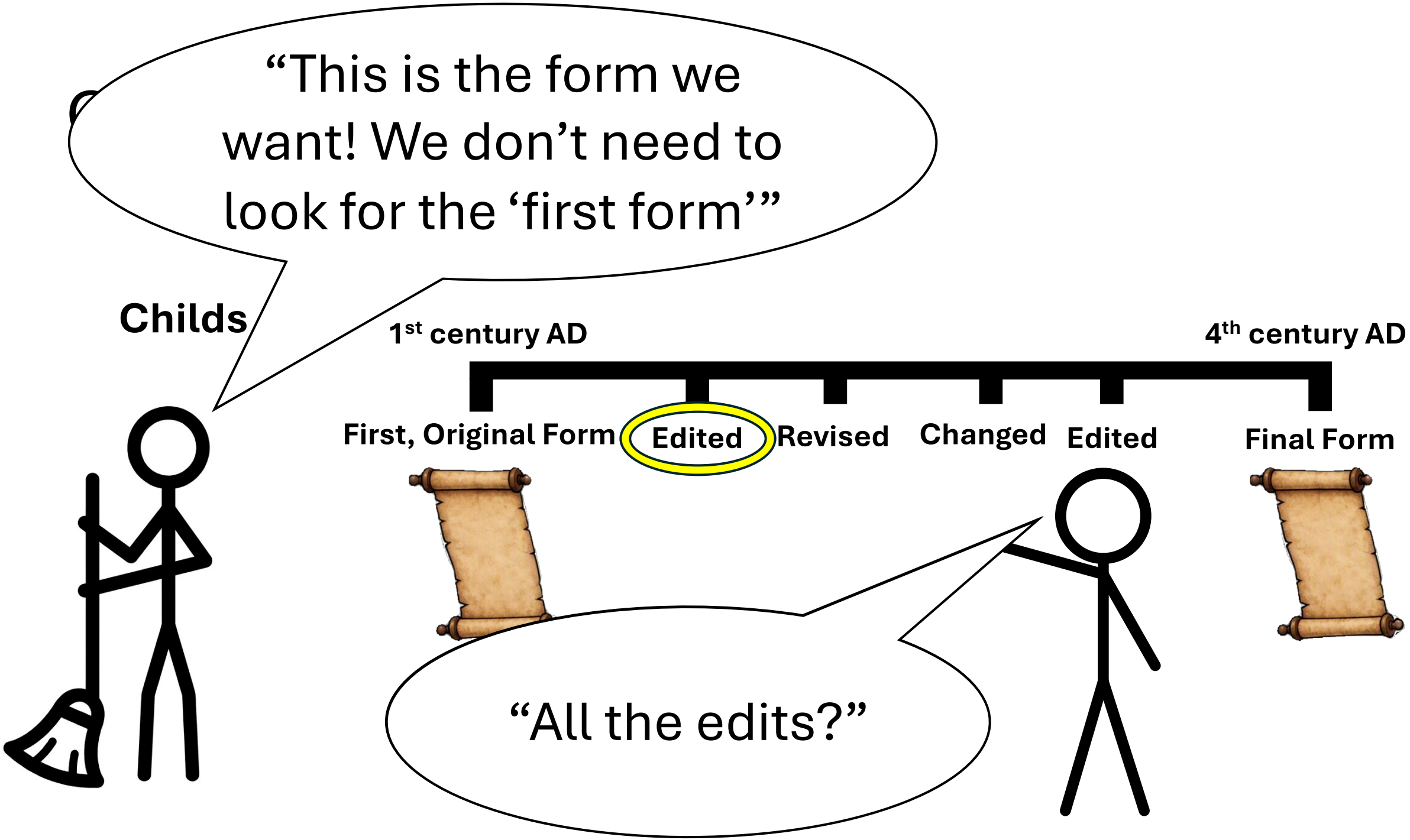
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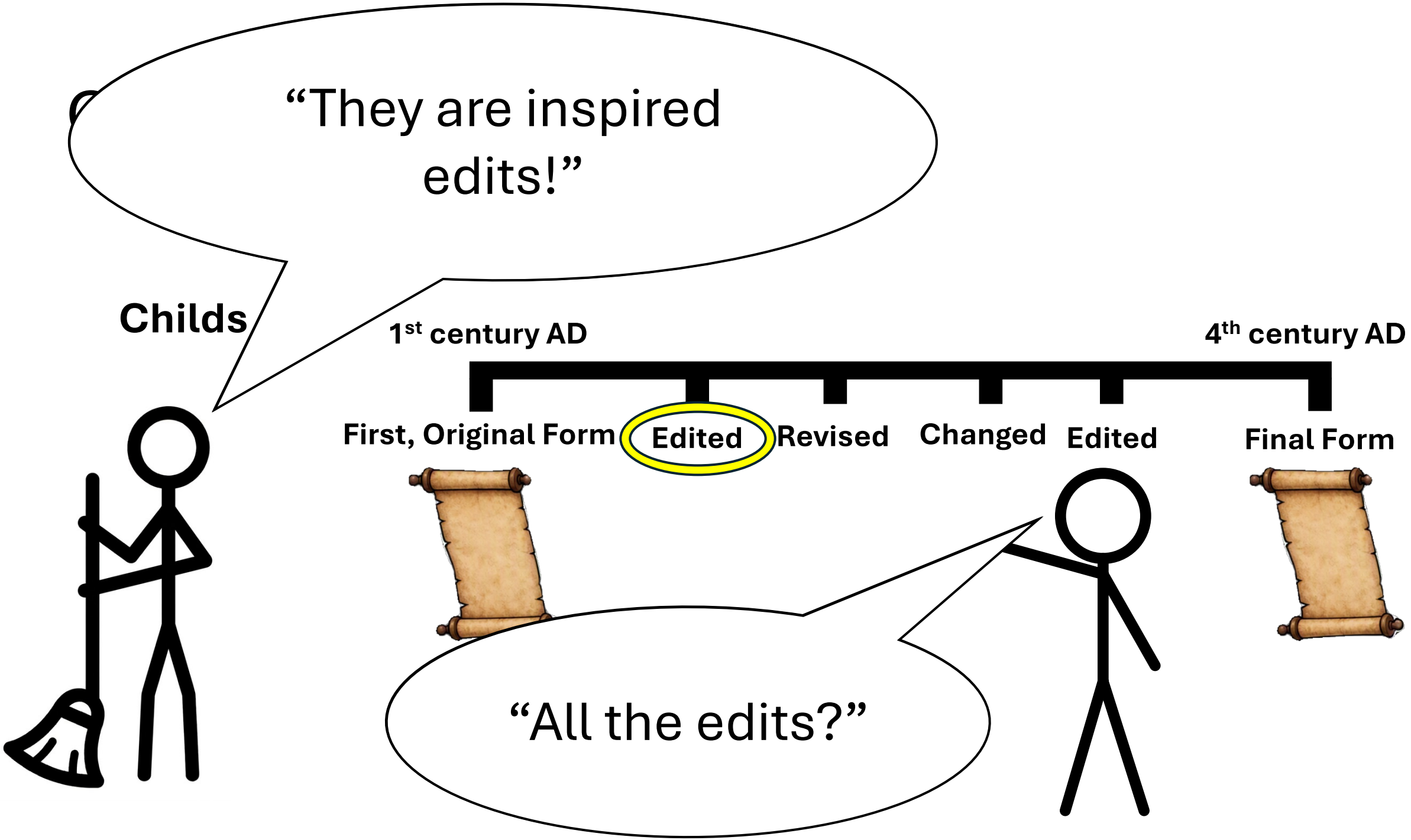
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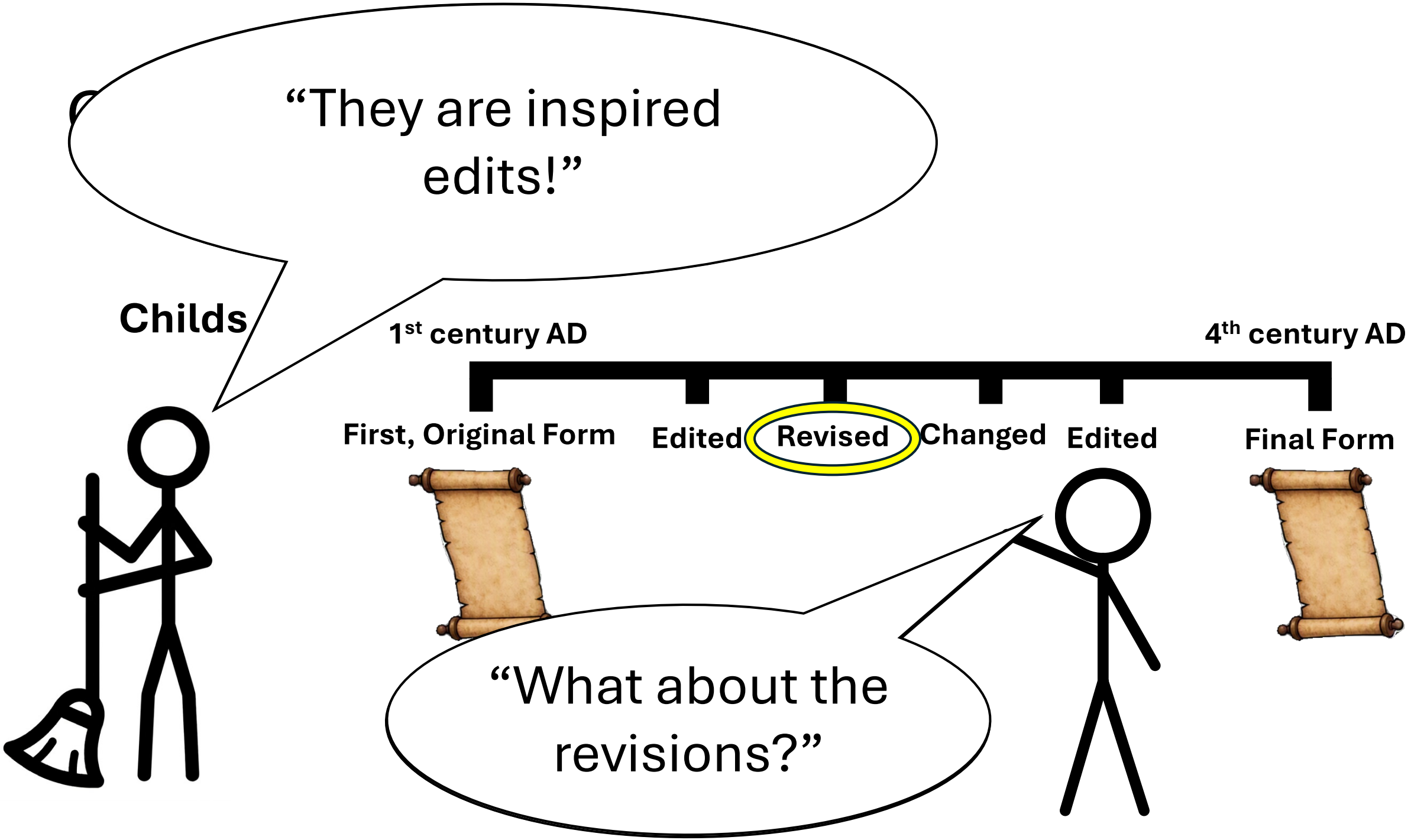


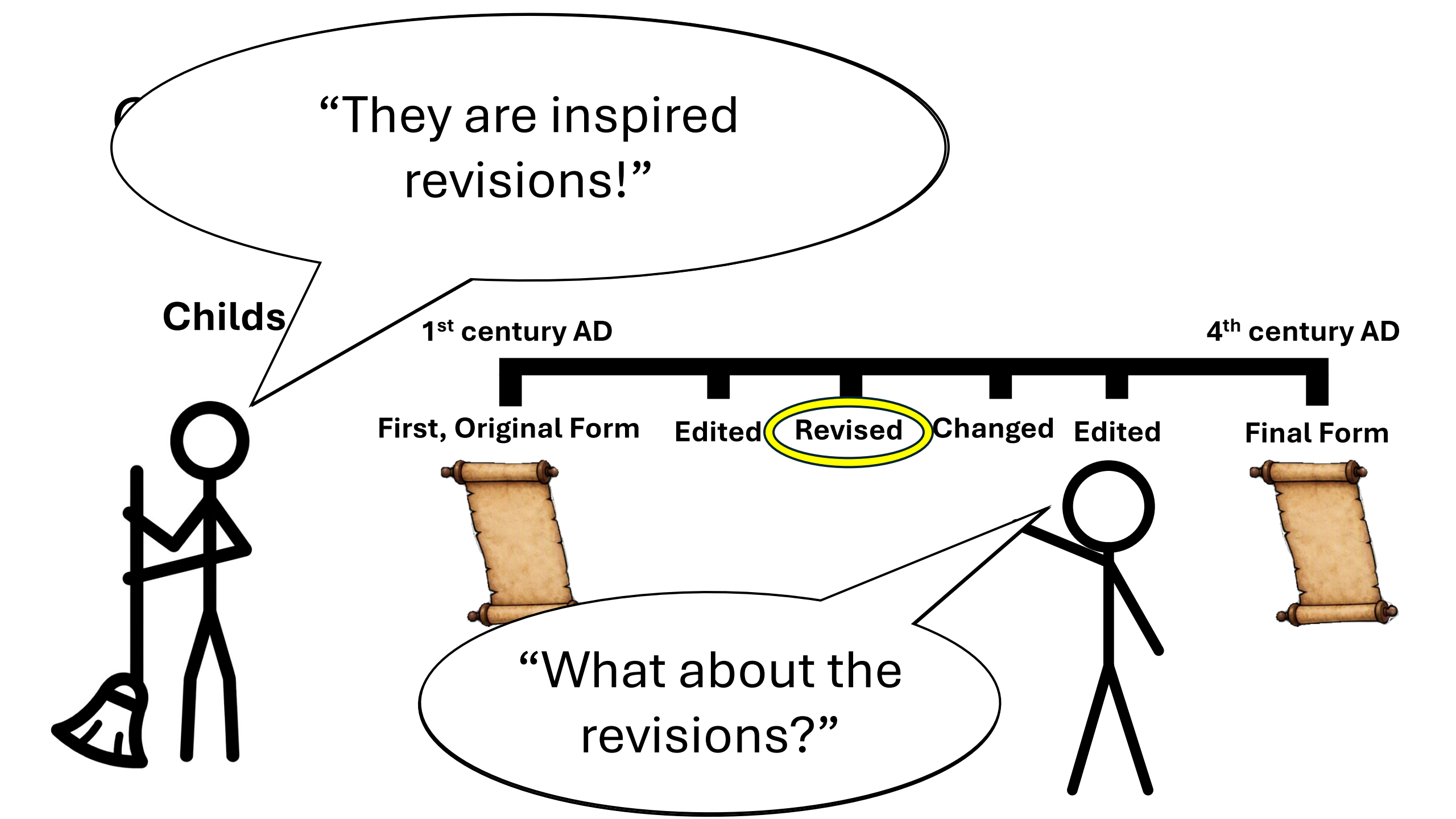


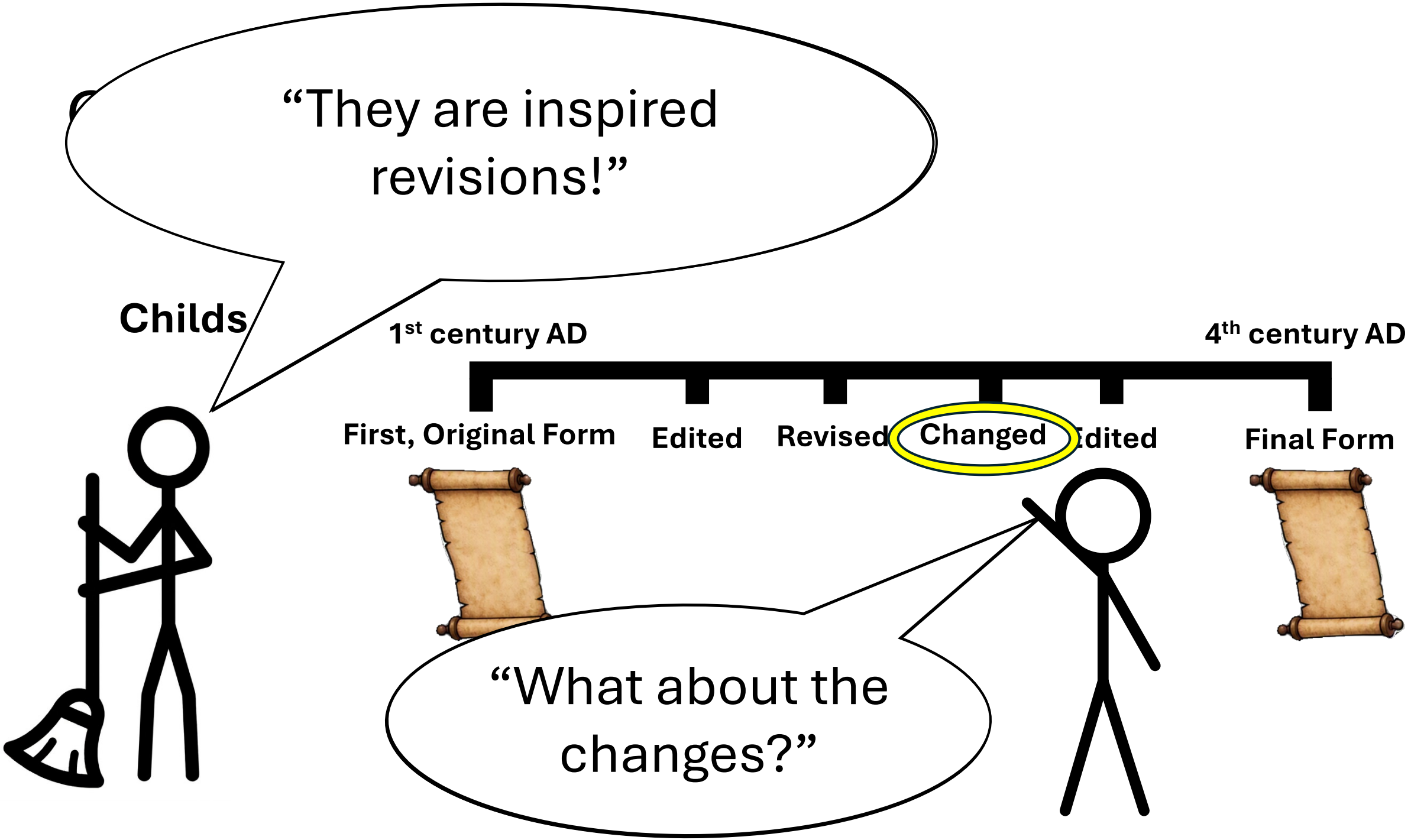

“This is the form we want! We don’t need to look for the ‘first form’”
Childs
1st century AD
4th century AD
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Revised
Changed
Edited
Final Form
“Okay but wait, what about…”

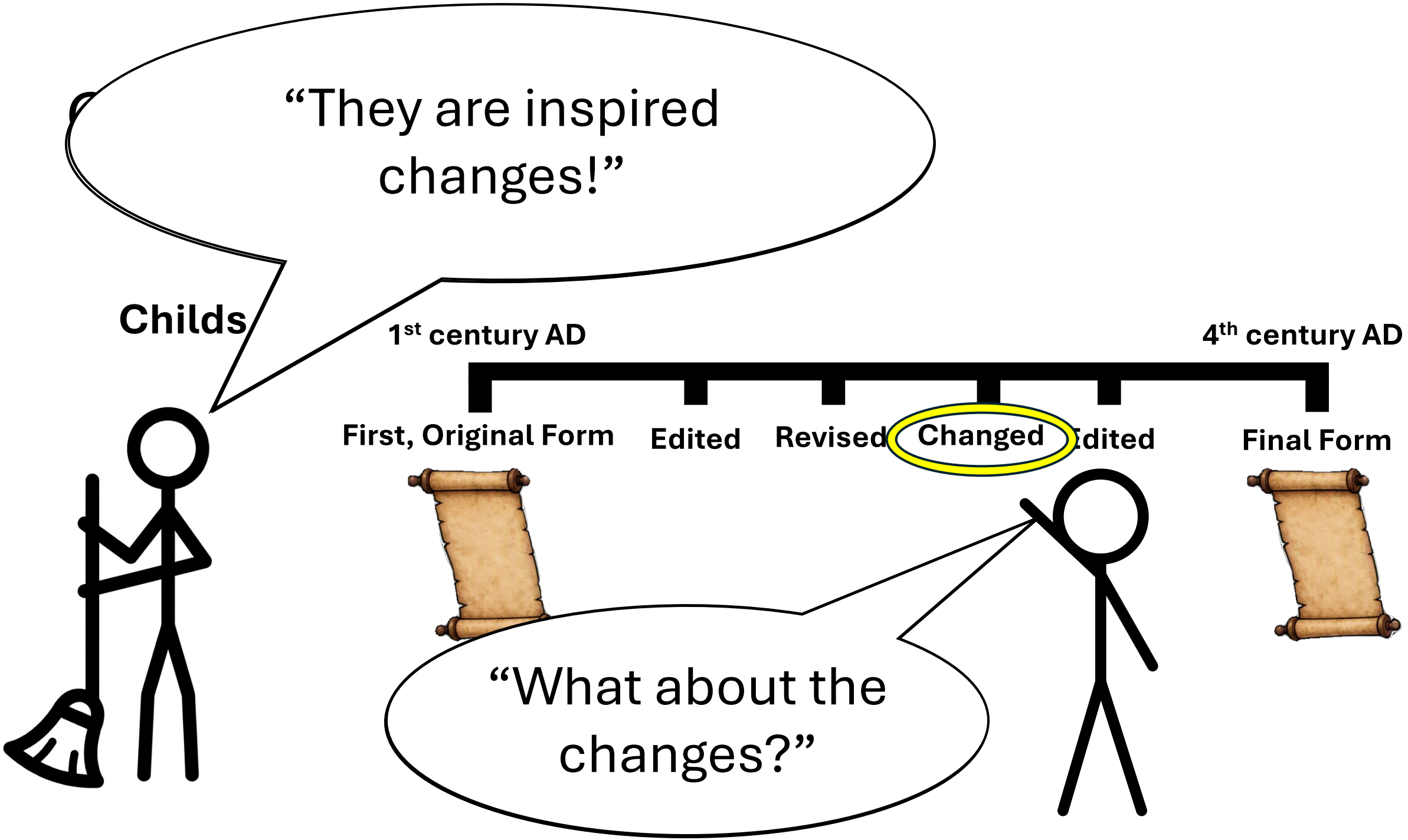

“This is the form we want! We don’t need to look for the ‘first form’”
Childs
1st century AD
4th century AD
First, Original Form
Edited
Revised
Changed
Edited
Final Form
“All the edits?”

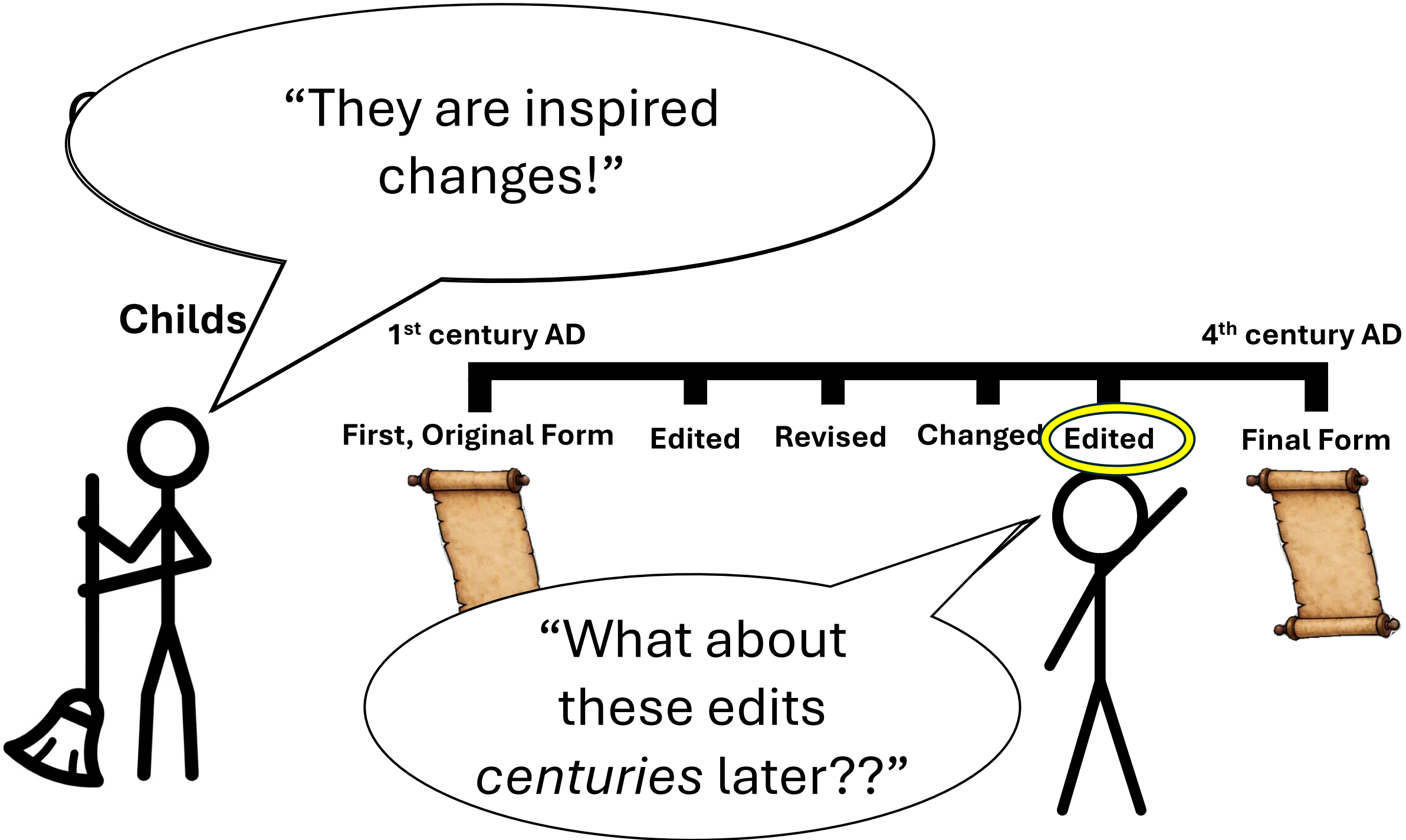

“They are inspired edits!”
Childs
1st century AD
4th century AD
First, Original Form
Edited
Revised
Changed
Edited
Final Form
“All the edits?”

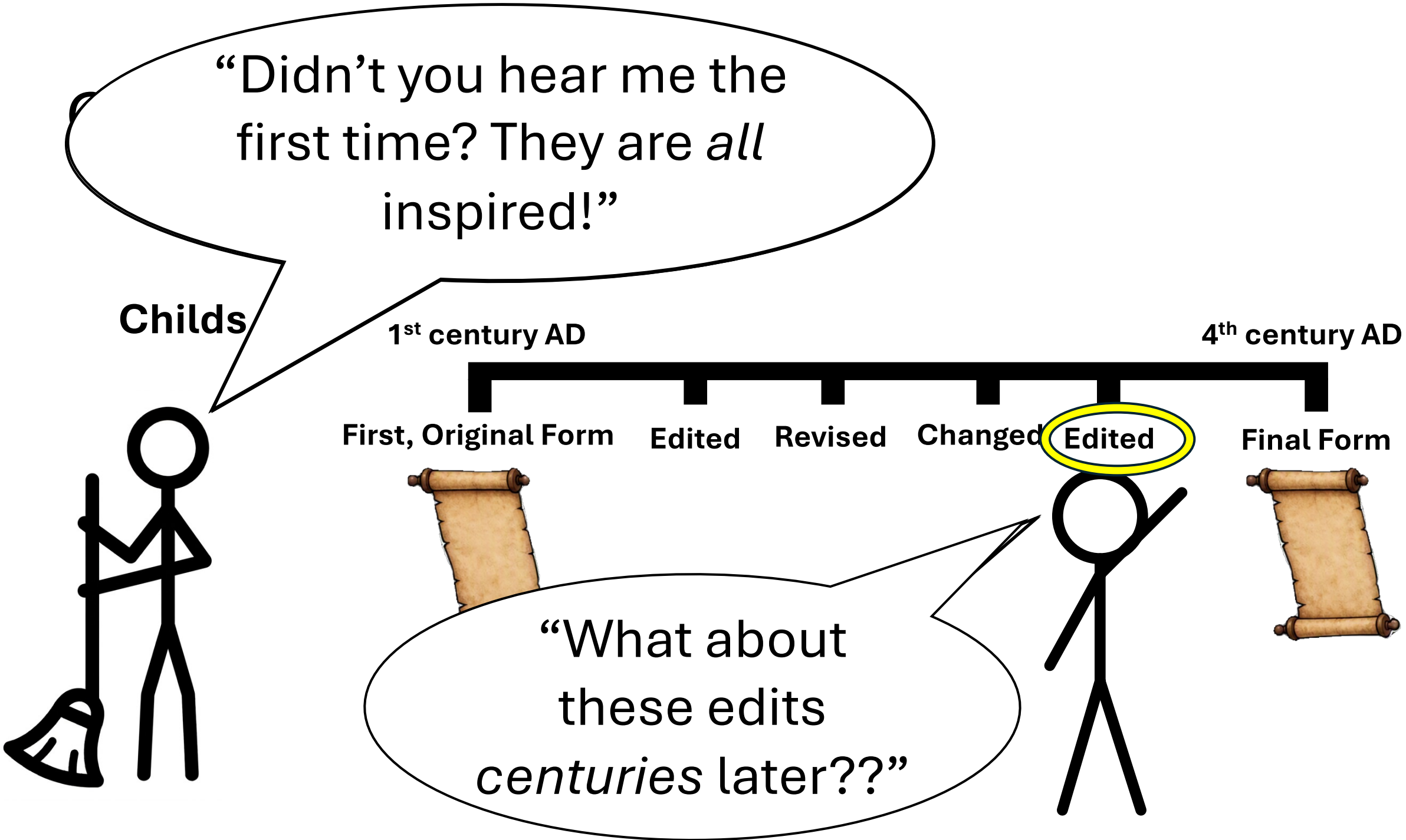

“They are inspired edits!”
Childs
1st century AD
4th century AD
First, Original Form
Edited
Revised
Changed
Edited
Final Form
“What about the revisions?”


“They are inspired revisions!”
Childs
1st century AD
4th century AD
First, Original Form
Edited
Revised
Changed
Edited
Final Form
“What about the revisions?”


“They are inspired revisions!”
Childs
1st century AD
4th century AD
First, Original Form
Edited
Revised
Changed
Edited
Final Form
“What about the changes?”


“They are inspired changes!”
Childs
1st century AD
4th century AD
First, Original Form
Edited
Revised
Changed
Edited
Final Form
“What about the changes?”


“They are inspired changes!”
Childs
1st century AD
4th century AD
First, Original Form
Edited
Revised
Changed
Edited
Final Form
“What about these edits *centuries* later??”


“Didn’t you hear me the first time? They are *all* inspired!”
Childs
1st century AD
4th century AD
First, Original Form
Edited
Revised
Changed
Edited
Final Form
“What about these edits *centuries* later??”

Canonical-Critical Model

- 2 Key Points:
  1. We want the final form, not the earliest
  2. The canon isn't "formed" in the 4th century; it is just finalized. The canon began the moment books started being used "as Scripture" ("The Functional Canon")

Canonical-Critical Model Evaluation

1. “Childs is hard-pressed to justify a sociological view of inspiration from the Scriptures themselves” (p. 53)
   - “The variety of biblical texts on the subject (and we cannot engage them here) give no indication that inspiration is a community affair, but rather view it as operative in key individuals and at key junctures in redemptive history. Robert Gnuse observes, ‘The biblical tradition does not seem to give a direct affirmation to the social model of group inspiration; rather the group always seems to be addressed or led by a chosen individual’” (p. 53)
2. “There is also no indication that the early church viewed itself as bearing the same degree of inspiration as the apostles, or as bearing the authority to add, change, or modify the Scriptures (either Old Testament or New)…. The church understood its role as the preserver of inspired texts, not the editor of them” (p. 53)

Canonical-Critical Model Evaluation

3. “If the canonical documents can be continually shaped by successive Christian communities, what is significant about the fourth-century community that gives it permanent normative status?” (p. 54)
    - “If the canonical documents were revisable for the first four centuries of the Christian church, then there seems to be no reason offered by Childs for why the canonical documents would not continually be open to revision even up to the present day. If so, then there can be no “final form” of the canon from which Childs can do his biblical theology” (p. 54)
4. “If the response to this problem is that the Christian community has the authority not only to shape, mold, and change the canonical documents, but also to decide when to stop the “canonical process” and create a final canonical version, then it is difficult to avoid the implication that the church bears more authority than the canon itself. Thus, canonical criticism finds itself in a very similar place as the Roman Catholic model” (pp. 54-55)

Canonical-Critical Model Evaluation

“Carl Henry, critiquing Childs’s position, puts it well: ‘If the canon represents a judgment by the community of faith … does not the community really constitute an authority just as ultimate, and even more so, than the canon?’” (p. 55)

Canonical-Critical Model Evaluation

"…to say that a book belongs in the canon [according to Childs] is simply to say that these books, and not others, are what the church has chosen as the best summary of what constitutes the Christian faith and the Christian gospel" (pp. 55-56)

"…the crux of the canonical-criticism model. The canon is "authoritative" not because it is historically true or derived from the apostles; it becomes authoritative when a particular community embraces it in faith" (p. 56)

Ironic: "While the modern critical methods may have overlooked the final text for the sake of getting to the historical reality "behind" it, Childs's canonical criticism has overlooked the historical reality behind it for the sake of focusing on the final text" (p. 56)

Canonical-Critical Model Evaluation

"This overemphasis on community reception, once again, creates a canon that is, in some sense, dependent upon the community it is intended to rule" (p. 57)

Canonical-Critical Model Evaluation

"...if the church is able to change the text along the way, what keeps it from changing it now? In other words, why does, and this is one of the key problems with canonical criticism, why does Childs freeze things in the fourth century? It's like for generations, generations, the church can change, modify, alter, and you finally get this final form which he sort of picks as the fourth century and said, well, there we stop. And there we stop and we don't do anything else to the text. But that seems a little bit arbitrary. If you can change it back then and change it all the way and inspiration is not in the original authors, then why can we not just change the text today? Why can't we get together as a church now and have community (you know, community inspiration) again and change it?"

(Dr. Michael Kruger, "PART 4 The Canonical Criticism & Existential Models" YouTube Video, minute 8:06-8:48)

1. Historical-Critical Model = Boxing Match
2. Roman Catholic Model = Church Created
3. Canonical-Critical Model = Church Formed
4. Existential/Neoorthodox Model = Experience

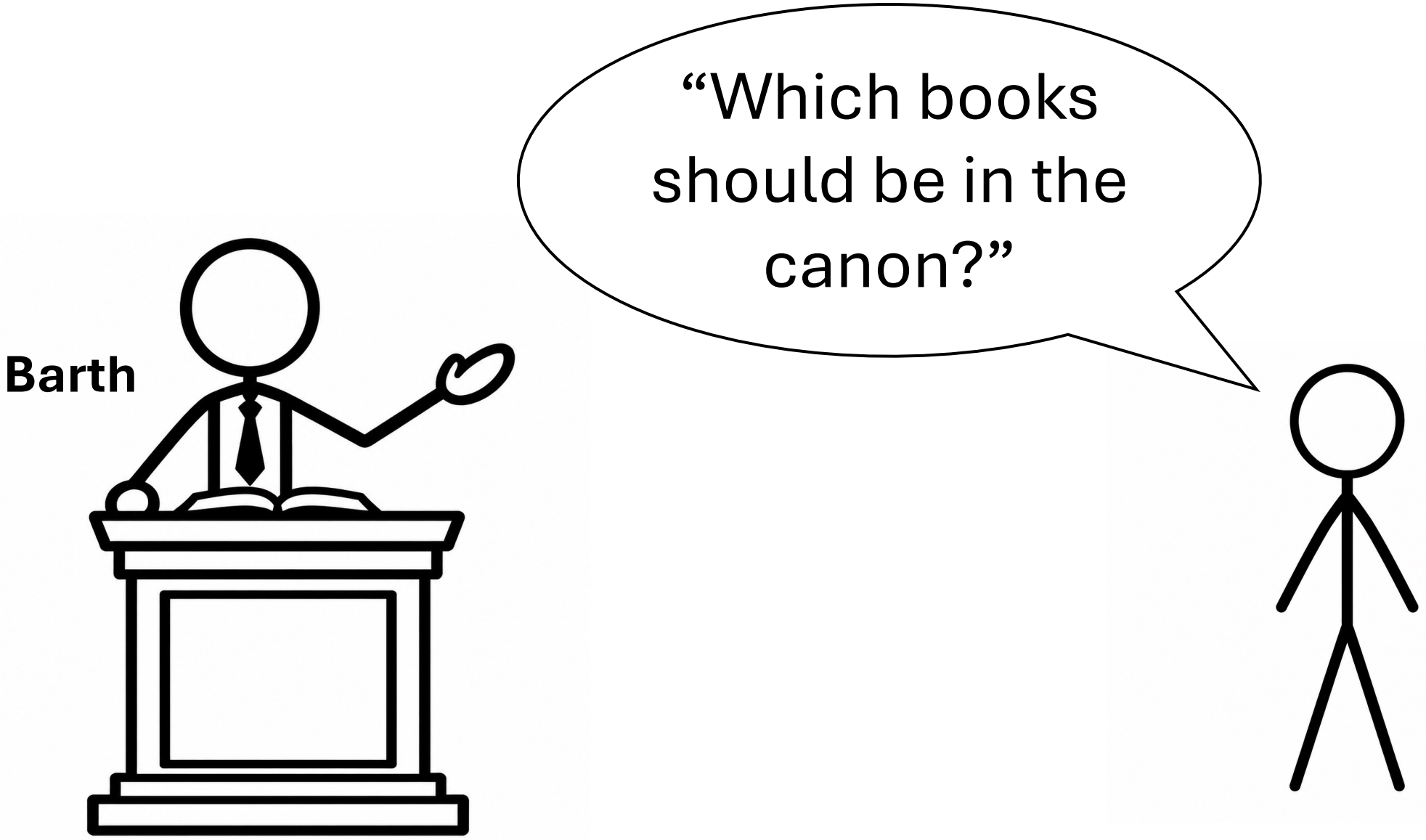
Existential/Neoorthodox Model

- Much more “individualistic and experiential” (p. 59)
- “The locus of authority is found not in the Scriptures themselves but ultimately in the individual who engages with them. Authority exists when (and only when) an individual experiences God’s word and responds to it in faith” (p. 59)
- Karl Barth a prominent figure for this model
  - “Barth (or Barthianism) believed that the Scriptures are not the word of God, per se, but merely a *witness* to the word of God (Jesus Christ). Revelation is not a propositional statement about God; rather it is an event (*Ereignis*), an encounter, something that “happens” to an individual. Thus, the Scriptures are not the word of God in a static sense, but “become” the word of God when an existential experience occurs” (p. 60)

Existential/Neoorthodox Model

- “Bultmann argues that it does not matter whether the New Testament reflects real history; the thing that matters is not the historical cross but the ‘preached cross.’ For Barth, Brunner, and Bultmann, what matters is the existential connection made with God through the Scriptures, not whether the Scriptures are historically ‘true’” (p. 61)
- Therefore, their definition of “the canon is defined as those books through which the church encounters the living voice of God” (p. 61)
- “For the existentialist, historical questions are not germane to the issue of canon in the first place; form criticism, source criticism, and investigations into the authorship or date of books are not the means by which one decides whether a book is part of Scripture. Christians do not experience God in the Scriptures because they are canonical; rather they are “canonical” because Christians experience God in them” (pp. 61–62)

Existential/Neoorthodox Model

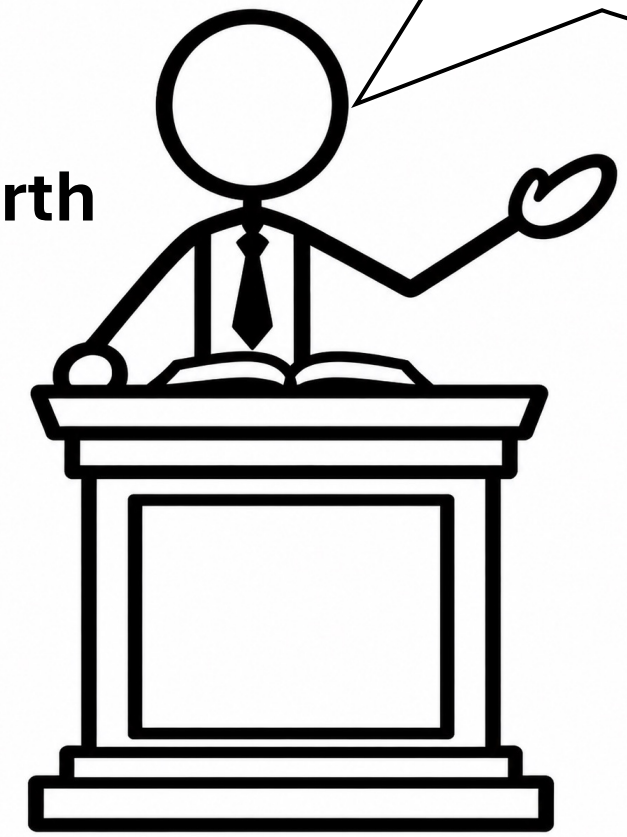


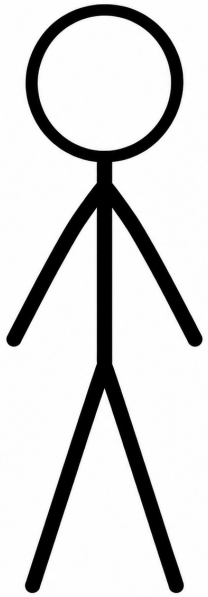
Existent Model

“All the books that people experience God’s voice”

oks in the canon?”

Barth



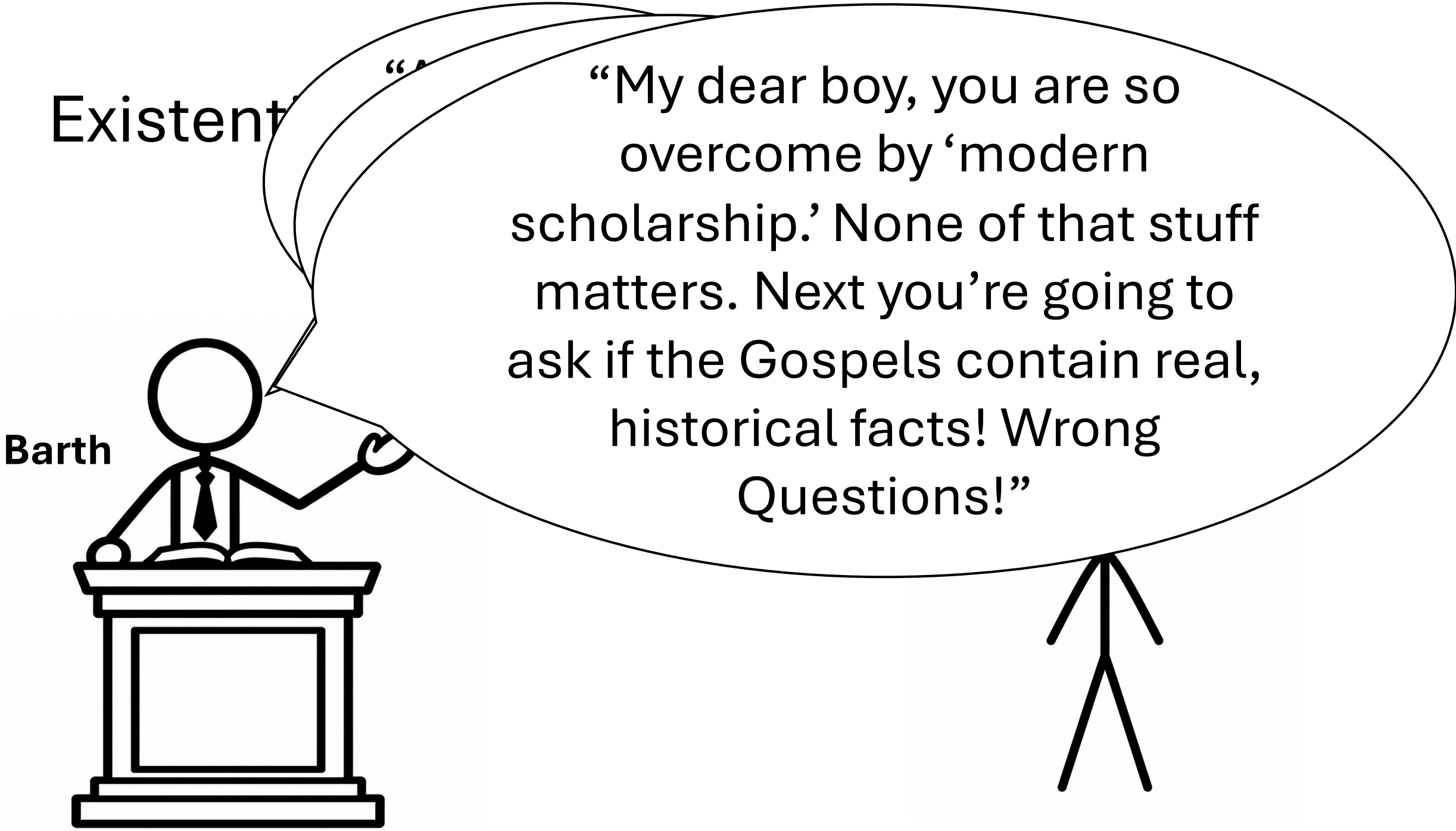


Existent

“Okay but what does that mean? What about authorship?”

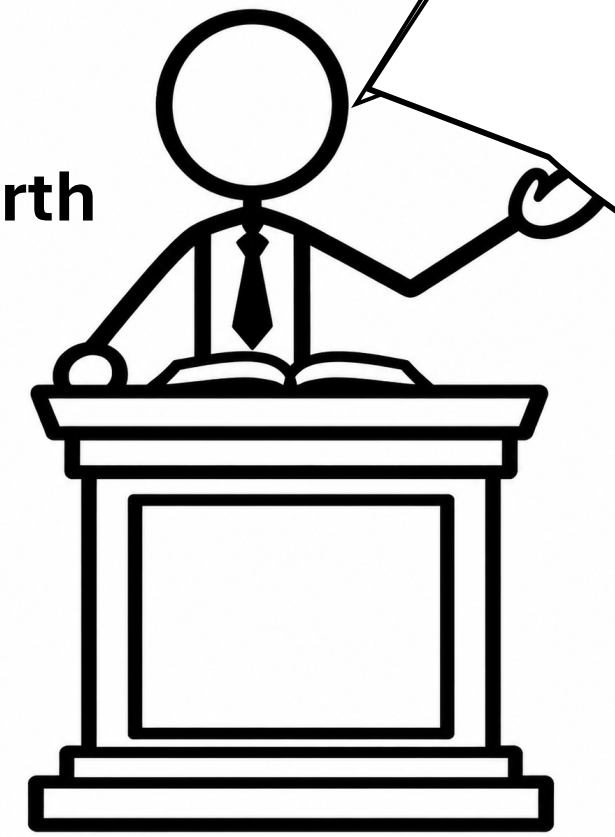


Existent


“My dear boy, you are so overcome by ‘modern scholarship.’ None of that stuff matters. Next you’re going to ask if the Gospels contain real, historical facts! Wrong Questions!”
Barth

Existent

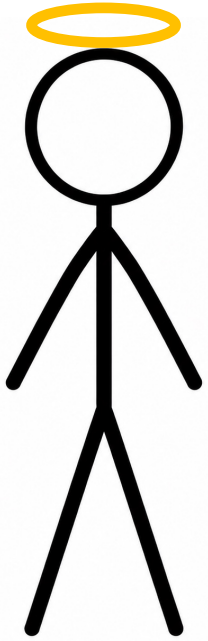
Barth



“What matters is that when people read these books, they hear God’s voice. Everything else is just extra stuff”

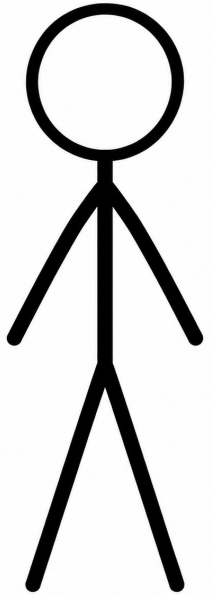
Existential/Neoorthodox Model

Jesus
“The Word of God”



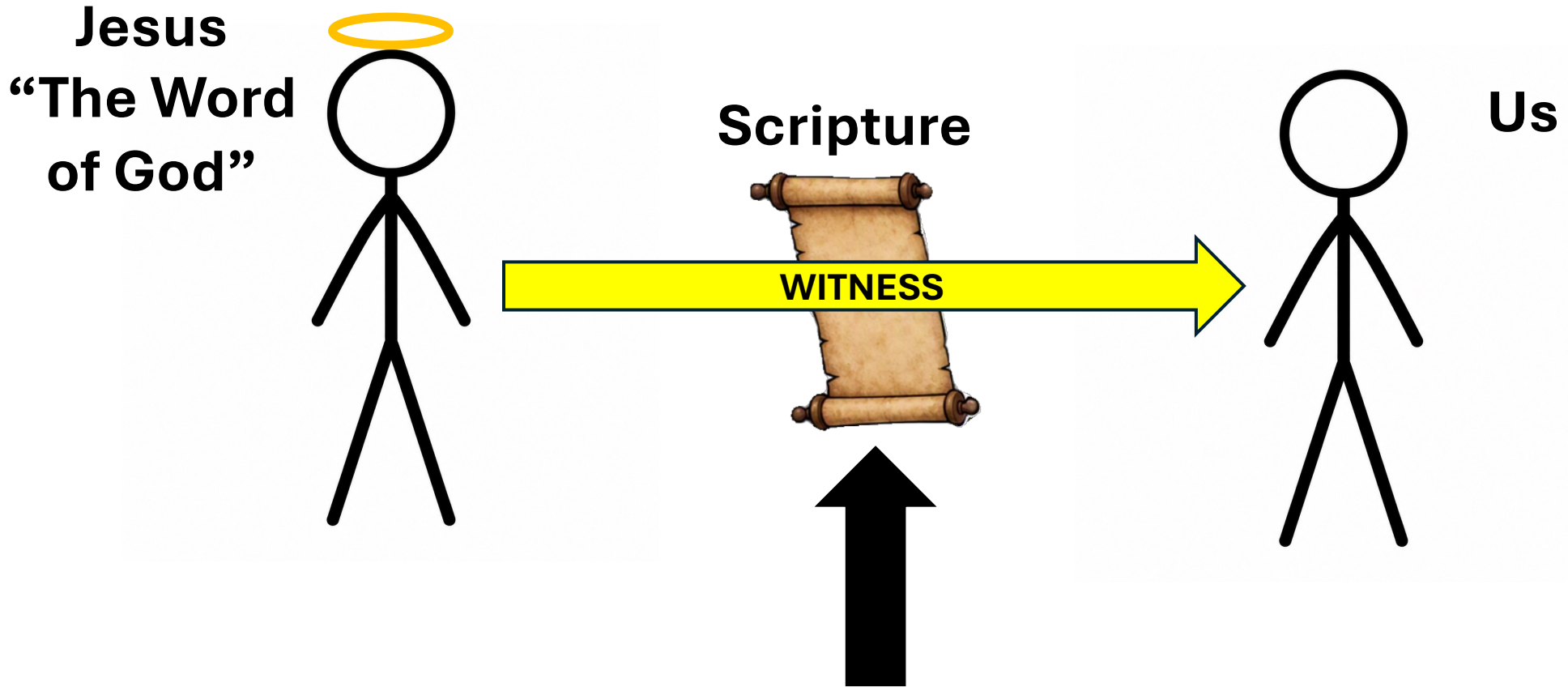
Scripture





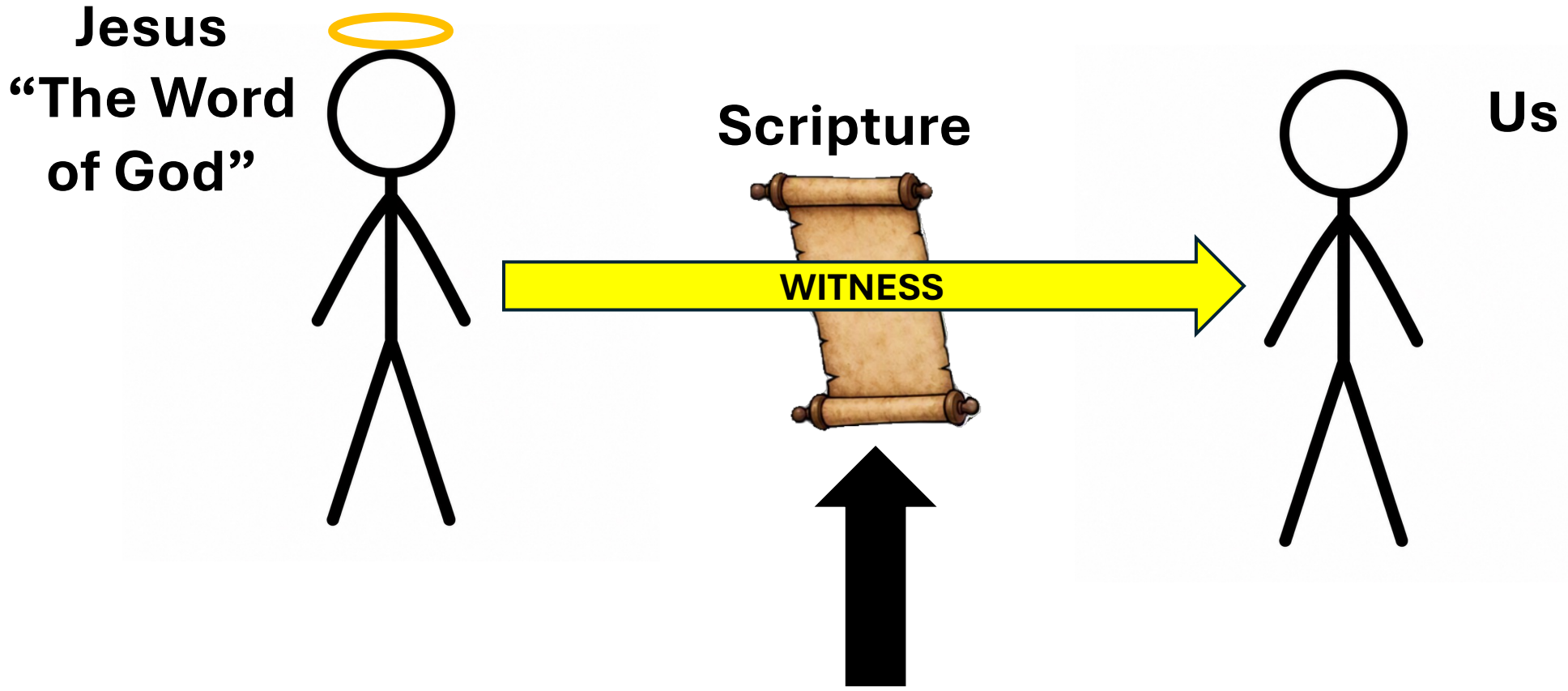
Us

Existential/Neoorthodox Model



Messed up, has contradictions, etc.
God still uses it

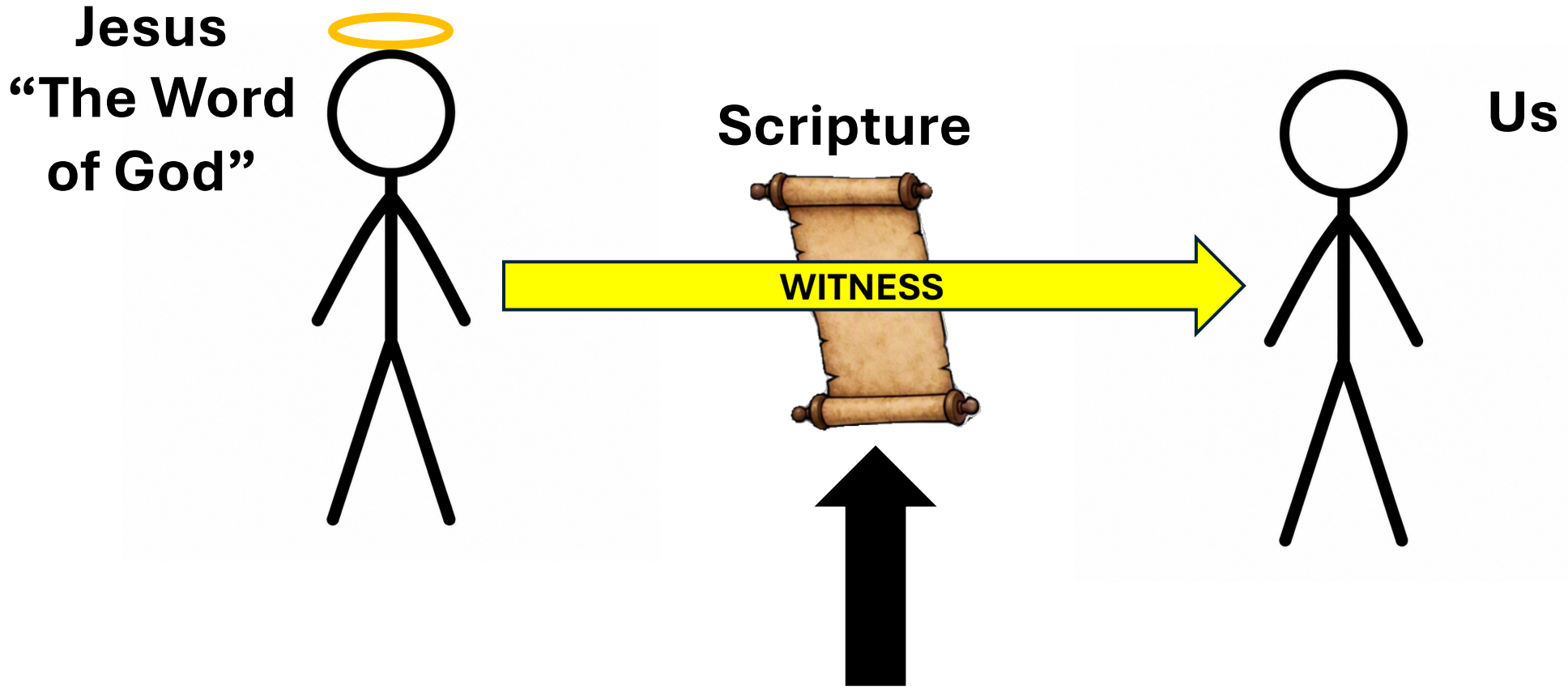
Existential/Neoorthodox Model



Agree with NT Critical Scholarship

God still uses it

Existential/Neoorthodox Model



Agree with NT Critical Scholarship

Affirm Divine Inspiration

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“So what…is Barth able to do? Barth is able to have his theological cake and eat it too if you will. What he was able to say is, ‘<u>this is the word of God</u> but yet I think <u>all the critical scholars are still right</u>’” (minute 35:10-35:19)

Michael Kruger, “PART 4 The Canonical Criticism & Existential Models,” YouTube Video

Agree with NT Critical Scholarship

Affirm Divine Inspiration

Existential/Neoorthodox Model

- “Barth appears quite committed to the idea that the sixty-six books of our canon are the only books that God uses to actively speak to his church. However, his downplaying of historical matters and his focus on existential matters prevent him from being able to provide any real basis for why we should be restricted to these certain books. Consequently, Barth “affirms the sixty-six books are the canon, but he leaves the door open to extensions” (p. 62)
- Brunner: “The question of the canon has never, in principle, been definitely answered, but is continually being reopened. Just as the church of the second, third, and fourth centuries had the right to decide … what was ‘Apostolic’ and what was not, on their own responsibility as believers, so in the same way every church, at every period in the history of the church, possesses the same right and the same duty” (as qtd on p. 63)

Existential/Neoorthodox Model

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“The implications of Brunner’s comments are clear. Which books are considered ‘apostolic’—and therefore in the canon—is determined by each generation’s *experience* with those books. Thus, the canon of Scripture has ‘fluid edges’ and will change from generation to generation” (p. 63)

Existential/Neoorthodox Model

"But Brunner goes even further and suggests what Barth only implied, namely, that God could speak to his church in books *outside* the Bible. After all, if truth is mediated through personal experience, who is to say that a person cannot hear God's voice in another book? Is God restricted by the Bible? Brunner simply takes his existential approach to its logical conclusion. Likewise, Bultmann also affirms that the 'word of God' is not to be equated with the Scripture, but he is even more radical in his existential approach to the Christian faith than are Barth and Brunner, causing some to criticize Bultmann for denying that a religious encounter requires *any* connection to a historical Jesus. Thus, Bultmann also leaves the door wide open to the possibility that such an encounter could happen through other books outside the canon"

(p. 63)

Existential/Neoorthodox Model

"Indeed, many of Bultmann's more radical successors (Karl Jaspers, Fritz Buri, and Van Austin Harvey) continued to make the case that existential fulfillment need not have anything to do with Christ at all, but could occur through other historical figures worthy of emulation—thus eliminating any need to consider the New Testament books as a unique source of revelation" (p. 63)

Existential/Neoorthodox Model Evaluation

- “The most fundamental concern pertains to the existential model’s unfortunate separation of the authority of God and the authority of Scripture” (p. 64)
  - “For Barth, ‘the texts are authoritative *not in virtue of any property they may have*.’ Consequently, these texts must be considered canonical on *other* grounds, namely, ‘in virtue of a function they fill in the life of the Christian community.’ But this leads to three problematic areas” (p. 64)

Existential/Neoorthodox Model Evaluation

- Three Problematic Areas:
  1. "…if the boundaries of the canon are determined solely by the existential experience of the community, then the boundaries of the canon are fluid and ever changing. And a perpetually uncertain canon is unable to function as an authoritative norm for the church. If the canon is regarded as an entirely personal and existential 'event,' then there can never be a 'right' canon, but simply the 'current' canon—the canon that the church is now using" (pp. 64-65)
     - "What is the Word of God for some need not be the Word of God for others—or can be, or not, at different times and places" (Henry on Barthian view as qtd on p. 65)

Existential/Neoorthodox Model Evaluation

- Three Problematic Areas:
  1. No “right” canon
  2. “…if Scripture does not bear authority in itself and is contingent upon reception by the community, then the community begins to take on authority equal to (if not greater than) that of Scripture” (p. 65)
     - “Just as in the Roman Catholic and canonical-criticism models above, it is unclear how this position is able to establish a canon that can function as an authority over the church” (p. 65)

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Existential/Neoorthodox Model Evaluation

- Three Problematic Areas:
  1. No “right” canon
  2. Community Authorship Over Scripture
  3. “…if the existentialist model is correct that there is nothing distinctive about the biblical books, then the very *concept* of a canon is in jeopardy” (p. 65)

Existential/Neoorthodox Model Evaluation

- Three Problematic Areas:
  3. "…if the existentialist model is correct that there is nothing distinctive about the biblical books, then the very *concept* of a canon is in jeopardy" (p. 65)
     - "We noted above that Barth (along with others) argues that the New Testament contains contradictions and historical mistakes (and for Bultmann, outright myth), but that God can speak through these documents anyway—that is, what matters is not history, but faith. But if accurately recounting God's historical acts does not matter—nor anything else inherent in these books—then why should we have any concern about the extent of the canon at all? If God can supernaturally speak through any book (in his sovereignty and power), then what difference does it make which books ended up in the canon? In this regard, Bultmann's extreme approach may prove to be the most consistent. If there is nothing distinctive about these books (in and of themselves), then canonical boundaries are nonsensical. And therefore a canon is nonsensical" (pp. 65-66)

Existential/Neoorthodox Model Evaluation

- Three Problematic Areas:
    1. No “right” canon
    2. Community Authorship Over Scripture
    3. The concept of “canon” in jeopardy

1. Historical-Critical Model = Boxing Match
2. Roman Catholic Model = Church Created
3. Canonical-Critical Model = Church Formed
4. Existential/Neoorthodox Model = Experience

1. Histo Critical Model = Boxing Match
2. Rom = Church Created
3. Canonical-Critic h Formed
4. Existential/Neoorthodox Mode Experience

Community Decided

"Largely overlooked in the above models are (1) the intrinsic authority and internal attributes of these books that makes them authoritative and (2) the historical origins of these books and the fact that they stem from the apostolic age and accurately capture the redemptive activities of God in Jesus Christ. As a result of these omissions, these models are left with a canon that is derived from and established by the church, and thus is unable to rule over the church. In effect, the canon has so much become the church's book that it is unable to be God's book" (p. 66)

1. Histo Critical Model = Boxing Match
2. Rom = Church Created
3. Canonical-Critic h Formed
4. Existential/Neoorthodox Mode Experience

5. Canon-within-the-Canon Model

Community Decided

Canon-within-the-Canon Model

- “In 1962, Kurt Aland published the now famous article ‘The Problem of the New Testament Canon,’ in which he argued that the formation of the canon was so laden with ‘imperfections and uncertainties’ that its final shape clearly includes books (and portions of books) that are problematic. Thus, the only way forward is to discover the ‘canon within the canon’ by reducing the New Testament to its core truths and selecting the parts that will bring ‘unity to the faith.’ How is this to be done? By an investigation into the “historical development” of these books to determine which parts are genuine and which are not” (p. 68)

Canon-within-the-Canon Model

- “Like the historical-critical model above, this model often shares the critical methodologies that arose during the Enlightenment and views the New Testament collection as a largely human construct. The difference, however, is in how each model responds to the human nature of the canon. While the historical-critical model is focused on the *reception* of these books and the natural causes for their selection by the early Christian community (Marcion, political power play, etc.), the canon-within-the-canon model is intent on exploring the *origins* of these books and finding the ‘core’ material that could be considered genuine” (p. 68)